

BLACK LEDGER

DESIGN BIBLE — v0.3 (Working Draft)

A Vehicular Combat Game

Inspired by the dark spirit of classic arena combat games

“Every debt comes due. The Ledger always balances.”

Fifteen playable characters · Ten arenas · Ten unlockable Collector bosses
Fourteen pickup weapons · Destructible, transformable battlefields

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1. VISION & DESIGN PILLARS

1.1 The One-Line Pitch

Black Ledger is a single-player vehicular combat game where fifteen broken people enter a tournament hosted by a cosmic accountant who promises to erase their greatest regret. They fight through a dying city held by his enforcers — the Collections — and the price of winning is always higher than they bargained for.

1.2 Tone Reference

The game's tone sits in the territory of psychological horror, industrial decay, and tragic inevitability. Imagine the atmosphere of Twisted Metal Black, the doomed-character framing of Silent Hill, the moral weight of Hellblazer, and the grimy industrial textures of David Fincher's Se7en.

1.3 Design Pillars

Every feature, asset, and line of dialogue should serve at least one of these pillars. If it serves none, cut it.

Pillar 1 — Weight & Consequence

Vehicles feel heavy. Every shot connects with impact. Every character's story carries real weight. No floaty arcade nonsense — this game has gravity, both physical and emotional.

Pillar 2 — Personal Damnation

Every character is the protagonist of their own tragedy. The player should be able to sympathize with each one, then watch in horror as their wish destroys them. The Auditor doesn't lie — the contestants lie to themselves.

Pillar 3 — Combat as Catharsis

The arena fights are brutal, fast, and viscerally satisfying. The horror lives in the cutscenes; the gameplay is empowering. Players should feel dangerous behind the wheel.

Pillar 4 — Atmosphere Over Spectacle

A single flickering streetlight is scarier than ten explosions. Lean into silence, decay, and dread. Save the spectacle for moments that earn it.

1.4 Target Audience & Platform

- Primary platform: PC (Steam) at launch.
- Target audience: 18+ players who grew up with Twisted Metal Black, Vigilante 8, or Carmageddon, plus fans of dark indie titles like Hotline Miami, Inscryption, and Mouthwashing.
- Expected rating: ESRB Mature 17+ / PEGI 18 for violence, blood, and dark themes.

- Expected runtime: 12-18 hours main story across the expanded roster; 50+ hours for full completion (all fifteen endings, all ten Collector unlocks, and Vault).

2. WORLD & PREMISE

2.1 The Ledger

The Ledger is a black, leather-bound book that has existed for longer than recorded history. Every soul has a page; every page has entries — debts, regrets, harms done and harms received. The Ledger is not a metaphor. It is real, and it is kept current.

The Ledger does not judge. It simply records. But the universe demands that books balance. When entries go unsettled long enough, the universe sends an accountant.

2.2 The Auditor

The Auditor is not a person. The Auditor is a function — a process the universe runs when too many debts accumulate. He appears human: a thin man in a charcoal suit, face always slightly obscured (by shadow, by static, by a hat brim, by the way light refuses to land on him). He speaks softly. He never raises his voice. He is unfailingly polite.

Every ten years, the Auditor opens The Black Ledger — a tournament held in a chosen dying city. He sends invitations to people whose pages are particularly unbalanced. The prize is simple: the winner gets one entry struck from their page. One regret, undone.

“You misunderstand. I do not grant wishes. I correct ledgers. The distinction will matter to you, eventually.” — The Auditor

2.3 The Catch

Contestants believe their wish erases an event. It does not. The Auditor erases the entry — and an entry is a relationship, a connection, a thread in the weave. To strike an entry, he must remove what the entry is attached to. The mother you saved by undoing the accident? She must now have never existed, because she was only in your life because of that accident's aftermath. The crime you uncommitted? The victim is still dead, just by a different hand — yours, in a different form.

Every winner walks away with their wish granted exactly as worded, and their life destroyed by what the wording required.

2.4 The Setting — Ashen Hollow

This tournament's chosen city. A mid-sized industrial town in the American Rust Belt, abandoned by its primary employer (a steel mill) in 1987. Population peaked at 80,000; now hovers around 14,000. Half the city is condemned. The mill itself still stands at the city's edge, a cathedral of rust.

The Auditor has been preparing Ashen Hollow for months. Streetlights flicker on schedule. Radios broadcast static interrupted by his voice. The contestants arrive over the course of one

night and discover the city has been remade into an arena — and that its ruins are already occupied.

2.5 Story Structure

v0.1 gave each character a single personalized final boss. v0.2 restructures the campaign around the ten arenas of Ashen Hollow, each one held by a Collector (see Section 6). The flow is now:

- Cold Open: An anonymous citizen receives a letter. The Auditor's voiceover introduces the premise.
- Hub: The player selects one of fifteen characters from a 'roster screen' framed as the Auditor's filing cabinet.
- Per-character campaign: Each character is routed through a sequence of six to eight of Ashen Hollow's ten arenas, interspersed with cutscenes that develop their backstory.
- Collector gates: Each arena is 'held' by a Collector boss. To leave an arena, the contestant must defeat its Collector — a hard, Twisted Metal-style fight (Section 4.6). The first time any Collector is beaten on any save, that Collector is freed and added to the playable roster (Section 6).
- Final Boss: Every campaign culminates at the Auditor's Office, where the Auditor himself is the final fight (Section 6.10).
- Ending: A 60-90 second cinematic showing the wish granted and its true cost.
- Endgame Unlocks — two axes. Care about everyone: completing all fifteen endings unlocks Vault and reveals the true nature of the Auditor (the canonical Ledger-closing ending). Collect everything: claiming all ten Collectors and then defeating the Auditor unlocks the Auditor himself as the ultimate playable character.

3. THE ROSTER

Fifteen launch characters, plus Vault as a hidden unlockable, plus ten Collector bosses that become playable on defeat (Section 6). Each character is defined by: archetype, backstory, vehicle, signature special weapon, voice/dialogue style, and ending. Stats are on a 1-10 scale (1=worst, 10=best in class) and must sum to a fixed total to ensure roster balance.

Stat budget: Speed + Armor + Handling + Special Power = 24 (out of a possible 40). This forces every launch character to have a meaningful weakness. (Collector bosses deliberately break this budget — see Section 6.)

Roster note (v0.2): v0.1's text referred to 'eight launch characters' but detailed seven (3.1–3.7). v0.2 adds eight new characters (3.8–3.15) to establish a true fifteen-character launch roster and resolve that discrepancy. Vault is renumbered to 3.16.

3.1 The Surgeon

I can save her. I have to be allowed to save her.

Quick Reference

Archetype	Tragic professional, control freak undone by a single failure
Age / Occupation	47 — Former cardiothoracic surgeon, stripped of license
Vehicle	Repurposed ambulance ('The Theater')
Signature Special	The Operating Table
Speed	5
Armor	7
Handling	5
Special Power	7

Backstory

Dr. Eli Vance was the kind of surgeon other surgeons quoted. Sixteen years at Mercy General, hundreds of saves, the kind of steady hands that don't tremble even on hour eleven. He had a daughter, Cora, age four, with a congenital heart defect. He told his wife he could fix it himself. He told the hospital board he could fix it himself. He could not fix it himself.

Cora died on his table at 11:47 PM on a Tuesday. The malpractice case was dismissed — there was no malpractice, only the unbearable arithmetic of a defect too complex for any surgeon, including her father. His wife left him. His license followed two years later, after the drinking and the failed reinstatement of three other patients he was no longer steady enough to save.

He lives in his car now. The ambulance was bought at auction. He converted it himself. He believes — has to believe — that if he wins, the Auditor will give him back the eleven minutes between 11:36 and 11:47 PM. He has rehearsed those eleven minutes for nine years.

Vehicle Design

A retired city ambulance, white paint stained yellow-brown from years of neglect. Red crosses on the sides have been crudely painted over with black, then re-painted in white again — as if he keeps changing his mind. The interior is visible through the windshield: surgical tools mounted to the dashboard, a heart monitor wired into the cabin (its flatline tone audible when he takes damage). The rear doors swing open to launch his weaponry. Handles like a heavy ambulance should — sluggish off the line but surprisingly composed at speed.

Signature Special Weapon

The Surgeon deploys a glowing red diagnostic field around himself in a small radius. Enemies who enter the field are 'diagnosed' — their weakest armor zone is exposed, and damage dealt to them for the next 8 seconds is doubled. The Surgeon himself heals slightly while standing in the field. The field plays a slowed, distorted heart-monitor sound. Encourages aggressive play in close quarters; punishes enemies who can't get away.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Soft, clinical, precise. Uses medical terminology even in casual contexts ('she presented with...'). Rarely shouts; when he does, it is terrifying. Voice actor reference: Sam Neill in Event Horizon, but quieter.

Intro Cinematic (≈30s)

Open on a still shot of an empty operating theater, dim. The Surgeon stands in scrubs, washing his hands. The water runs red. He doesn't react. Cut to the ambulance idling in rain outside a closed hospital. He steps in, places a child's stuffed rabbit on the dashboard, and adjusts it with surgical care. Voiceover (his own voice, addressing himself): 'You will not shake. You will not blink. You will save her this time.' The ambulance pulls away. Title card: THE SURGEON.

Ending Cinematic (≈60-90s)

He wins. The Auditor sits across from him in the operating theater, now restored to pristine white. The Auditor says: 'The entry has been struck.' The Surgeon looks at his hands; they are steady. He understands. He drives home. The house is bright, warm. His wife is there. She doesn't recognize him — she is younger, happier, married to someone else who is not him. From the kitchen, a little girl runs out. 'Daddy!' she calls, and she runs past the Surgeon to the man behind him. The Surgeon was never her father. The defect was never his to fix. He saved her by never existing in her life. The camera holds on his face for ten silent seconds. Cut to black.

3.2 Hollow

The fire said it was hungry. I only fed it.

Quick Reference

Archetype	Amnesiac arsonist, masked menace with a tragic core
Age / Occupation	Unknown (appears 30-40) — Itinerant arsonist
Vehicle	Charred fire engine ('Pyre')
Signature Special	Conflagration
Speed	3
Armor	9
Handling	4
Special Power	8

Backstory

Nobody knows his name. He has been picked up by police in six states over fourteen years; each time, his fingerprints don't match any database. His face — when he removes the mask — has burn scars that obscure his features. He wears a faded firefighter's mask repurposed as a hood, the visor cracked.

He doesn't remember why he burns things. He only remembers that he must. The compulsion is not malicious in his mind — it is owed. Something is owed to fire. He has theories that come to him in dreams: a house, a stairwell, two small voices calling for him. He doesn't know if he was trying to save them or if he started the fire.

He wants to remember. The Auditor's offer is the first thing in fourteen years that has felt like it might give him an answer.

Vehicle Design

A 1970s pumper fire truck, blackened from end to end as if it drove out of a furnace. Ladder still mounted, but warped. The chrome bell on the front is the only thing not scorched — it gleams unnaturally. When he uses his special, the bell rings. The truck leaves a faint heat-haze trail. Handling is poor due to the weight, but armor is enormous.

Signature Special Weapon

Hollow opens a hidden valve and sprays a 180-degree cone of accelerant in front of his truck, then ignites it. Enemies caught in the cone burn for 6 seconds, taking damage over time and having their accuracy reduced (their gunner's view is obscured by smoke). The fire lingers on the ground for 3 seconds as a damage zone. Best used to control chokepoints.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Quiet, halting, like a man speaking through a damaged throat. Rarely uses pronouns ('the fire,' 'the house,' 'the small ones'). Long pauses. Voice actor reference: Doug Bradley as Pinhead, dialed down 60%.

Intro Cinematic (≈30s)

Open on a burning building at night. Hollow stands in the street watching it, fire reflected in his cracked visor. A child's bicycle lies in the yard, untouched. He stares at it. A tear runs down his cheek — but he is smiling under the mask. He turns away, climbs into Pyre, and drives off. Title card: HOLLOW.

Ending Cinematic (≈60-90s)

He wins. The Auditor takes him to a suburban street he doesn't recognize but his hands shake walking it. They stop in front of a two-story house. The Auditor opens the front door. Hollow walks in. He remembers. He set the fire — but only to make the insurance pay, to save his family from foreclosure. He didn't know they hadn't gotten out. The two voices were his daughters. He stayed long enough to drag them from the smoke but they did not survive the burns. He has spent fourteen years lighting fires looking for the moment he could have run faster. The Auditor stands in the doorway. 'The entry has been struck.' Hollow looks down. His hands are unburned. He is a young man again. He hears, very faintly, two little girls laughing from upstairs. He starts toward the stairs. The Auditor closes the door behind him. We never see what is upstairs. The screen holds black for a long beat. Then, very softly: the sound of fire.

3.3 Miss Antoinette

They called me the most beautiful woman in three states. Past tense is unkind.

Quick Reference

Archetype	Faded beauty, vanity-driven horror
Age / Occupation	Officially 28. Actually 71. — Former pageant queen, current recluse
Vehicle	Pink Cadillac convertible ('Forever Yours')
Signature Special	Powder Compact
Speed	8
Armor	3
Handling	6
Special Power	7

Backstory

Adeline Marchetti won Miss Tennessee in 1973. She won Miss Mid-South in 1974, 1975, and 1976. She was on the cover of three magazines and dated a senator's son. She believed, with the full conviction of someone who had never been told otherwise, that her face was her contract with the world.

The contract expired. She tried to renew it — surgeries, treatments, increasingly experimental therapies from doctors who shouldn't have had licenses. The results were temporary, then ruinous. By the time she was sixty, she had spent her inheritance and her face had been rebuilt

three times. Now she lives in a closed-off wing of her family home, the mirrors covered. She has not been photographed in fifteen years.

The Auditor's letter arrived in a pink envelope. She believes — wants to believe — that he will undo it. All of it. Give her back the face the world owed her.

Vehicle Design

A 1957 Cadillac Eldorado, painted glossy pink with chrome trim. Beautiful from twenty feet away. Up close: the leather interior is rotted, mildew-stained, a faint smell of decay. The hood ornament is a small chrome figure that, on close inspection, resembles Antoinette as a young woman. The car runs perfectly — too perfectly, as if it shouldn't. Top speed is excellent; armor is minimal.

Signature Special Weapon

Antoinette flips open a giant compact mirror mounted to the side of her car. For 5 seconds, all enemy lock-on weapons (homing missiles, etc.) targeted at her are reflected back at the sender. Visual: a brilliant burst of pink-and-gold light, with the compact rotating slowly. A defensive special that punishes missile-spammers.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Honeyed Southern drawl, performatively warm but with claws underneath. Speaks of others' looks constantly, often cruelly. Voice actor reference: Jessica Lange in *American Horror Story*.

Intro Cinematic (~30s)

Open in a darkened bedroom. A figure sits at a vanity, back to camera. We see only her hands — slender, with manicured nails, but the skin is loose, age-spotted. She reaches up and slowly removes a velvet cloth from the mirror. We see her reflection only as a blur of light — the camera refuses to focus on her face. She smiles. We see the smile in shadow. 'It's time, darling. One last show.' She rises, dressed in immaculate pink. The Cadillac waits. Title card: MISS ANTOINETTE.

Ending Cinematic (~60-90s)

She wins. The Auditor presents her with a single hand mirror, ornate and silver. 'The entry has been struck.' She looks in. She is twenty-three again — flawless, radiant, the face she wore on magazine covers. She weeps with joy. She races home. She unveils every mirror in the house. In every mirror, she is twenty-three. But she catches her reflection in a window pane that night and sees the truth: she is still seventy-one. The mirrors are lying. Anyone who looks at her sees youth — she alone sees age. The Auditor erased her entry in the world's perception, but he could not erase her from her own. She lives the rest of her life unable to be alone with her own reflection. She covers every reflective surface in her house. She lasts six months before she shatters every mirror she owns. The final shot is her sitting in the dark, surrounded by broken glass, finally smiling. The shards on the floor show a young woman, smiling back.

3.4 The Warden

He told me he was innocent. I had heard that every day for twenty years.

Quick Reference

Archetype	Hardened authority figure haunted by one mistake too many
Age / Occupation	61 — Retired prison guard, formerly a Captain at Ridgemont State Penitentiary
Vehicle	Armored prison transport ('The Cage')
Signature Special	Solitary
Speed	4
Armor	9
Handling	4
Special Power	7

Backstory

Captain Marcus Reilly worked Ridgemont for thirty-one years. He was respected, feared, and famously incorruptible. He had a phrase he used with new guards: 'Every man here says he's innocent. Treat them all the same.'

In 2009, inmate Daniel Voss told him he was innocent. Voss was scheduled for transfer to general population that week from solitary. Voss told Reilly that a man in general would kill him on day one over an old debt. Voss begged. Reilly transferred him on schedule. Voss was dead within nine hours.

Three years later, DNA evidence cleared Voss of the original crime. He had, in fact, been innocent. Reilly resigned within the month. He has spent the years since reading every word of Voss's case file, again and again. He keeps a photograph of Voss on the dashboard of the van. He believes if he wins, he can transfer Voss back to solitary. He can keep him alive. He can be the man who listened.

Vehicle Design

A black GMC prison transport van, reinforced steel mesh over the windows, county insignia partially scratched off. The rear is a barred holding compartment — empty, but with one set of handcuffs hanging from the ceiling that swings ominously even when the van is still. Solid armor, slow acceleration, brutal weight in collisions.

Signature Special Weapon

The Warden fires a single heavy chain projectile from a launcher on the van's roof. On hit, the chain wraps the target vehicle in spectral chains for 4 seconds — they cannot move, cannot fire, cannot use specials. A devastating control ability with limited ammo (2 charges per match). Devastating in 1v1; useful for setting up team-finishes in free-for-all.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Gravel-voiced, terse, military-cadence. Speaks in short sentences. Uses prison and law-enforcement jargon. Voice actor reference: J.K. Simmons in *Whiplash*, but older and quieter.

Intro Cinematic (≈30s)

Open in a prison visitor's room, empty. The Warden sits across from an empty chair, hands folded. He speaks to no one. 'I should have listened.' Cut to him in uniform packing a locker — the badge goes in a box; the photograph of Voss goes in his pocket. Cut to him climbing into the Cage in the present, the photograph going onto the dashboard. He starts the engine. Title card: THE WARDEN.

Ending Cinematic (≈60-90s)

He wins. The Auditor stands in the empty cellblock at Ridgemont. 'The entry has been struck.' The Warden walks to Voss's old cell. The door is open. Voss is inside, alive, healthy, exactly as he was the day before the transfer. Voss looks up. 'You came back.' The Warden steps in. The door closes behind him automatically. Voss stands up — and walks out of the cell. The door doesn't open for the Warden. He is in the cell now. He will serve Voss's sentence, in his place. From outside, Voss looks at him with no emotion. 'Every man in here says he's innocent.' The Auditor's voice, distant: 'The entry has been struck.' The Warden was the entry. He gave the years he owed.

3.5 Pup

Pup just wants to go home. Pup doesn't want to be alone anymore.

Quick Reference

Archetype	Innocent-seeming horror, ambiguous monster-or-victim
Age / Occupation	Appears 8. Has been 8 for an unknown amount of time. — None. Drives an ice cream truck.
Vehicle	Ice cream truck ('Sundae')
Signature Special	Storytime
Speed	7
Armor	4
Handling	8
Special Power	5

Backstory

Pup is not the child's name. Pup doesn't remember the child's name. Pup remembers a backyard, a swing set, a mother calling for dinner, and then the ice cream truck — and then the truck and Pup were one thing, and the backyard was a long time ago.

The game leaves Pup's nature deliberately ambiguous. Possible interpretations: a child who was killed in 1987 by an ice cream truck driver and whose ghost merged with the vehicle; a creature that has always existed wearing a child's appearance to lure victims; a manifestation of the Auditor's office itself. Pup's dialogue supports all three.

Pup wants to 'go home,' but home isn't a place. Home, in Pup's vocabulary, is a moment — the moment before something happened. Pup cannot describe the something.

Vehicle Design

A 1980s ice cream truck, faded pastel colors, peeling decals of cartoon characters whose features look slightly wrong (one eye too low, a smile that goes past the ear). The jingle plays from a tinny speaker — a warped, slowed version of 'Pop Goes the Weasel' that sometimes skips and reverses. The truck is small and surprisingly fast. The freezer in the back is always frosted over. Sometimes the truck appears in the rearview mirror of other cars before it's anywhere near them.

Signature Special Weapon

Pup leans out of the truck's serving window and tells a story over the loudspeaker. For 6 seconds, all enemies within a large radius have their controls inverted (forward is back, left is right) and their HUD displays childlike crayon drawings of crashes. A control ability that creates chaos in group fights. Cooldown: 25 seconds.

Voice & Dialogue Style

A child's voice, recorded at slightly the wrong speed — sometimes too slow, sometimes too fast. Refers to self in third person. Voice actor reference: any small child, post-processed with subtle pitch shift and reverse-reverb tail.

Intro Cinematic (≈30s)

Open on a residential street in summer daylight — but the colors are oversaturated, almost wrong. The ice cream truck rolls slowly past empty houses. The jingle plays. We see Pup through the serving window: a child in a yellow t-shirt and shorts, face in shadow. A single child's drawing flutters from the truck and lands on the road behind it. We see the drawing: a stick figure family of three under a black scribble that might be a cloud. Title card: PUP.

Ending Cinematic (≈60-90s)

Pup wins. The Auditor stands in a backyard with a swing set. Late afternoon, golden light. 'The entry has been struck.' Pup climbs onto the swing. A woman's voice from offscreen: 'Pup! Honey, dinner!' Pup smiles — we see Pup's face for the first time, and it is a perfectly normal eight-year-old boy. Pup runs toward the house. Cut to black. Then: the ice cream truck, abandoned by the curb in front of the now-empty house. The jingle is still playing. Slowly, the driver's-side door opens. Something we don't see climbs out. The jingle stops. We hear, very faintly, a child's voice from inside the truck saying, 'It's your turn now.' Cut to black. (Implication left ambiguous: did Pup go home, or did Pup escape and pass the curse to someone else? Player chooses what to believe.)

3.6 Crucible

I was the foreman. They were my men. I gave the order to stay.

Quick Reference

Archetype	Working-class tragic hero, guilt-ridden survivor
Age / Occupation	54 — Former steel mill foreman, current scrap hauler
Vehicle	Slag hauler ('Bessemer')
Signature Special	Pour
Speed	2
Armor	10
Handling	3
Special Power	9

Backstory

Anton 'Tony' Bessemer worked Crucible Steel in Ashen Hollow for twenty-eight years, the last six as shift foreman. On October 14, 2003, a structural support in Furnace Three failed during a pour. Tony saw the warning signs four minutes before the collapse. He gave the order for his men to finish the pour before evacuating — a decision driven by quotas and the conviction that the support would hold for another thirty seconds.

It did not. Eleven men died. Tony was outside the structure when it came down, having gone to retrieve a safety officer. He lived. The investigation found him technically not at fault — the support's failure was structural, predating his shift — but he knew what he had said. He had said: 'Finish the pour.' He had been afraid of falling behind.

Tony has driven a scrap hauler in Ashen Hollow for the twenty-three years since. He drinks at the same bar every night. He has never spoken about that day, including to his wife, who left him in 2008. The Auditor's letter is the first thing he has wanted to win in two decades.

Vehicle Design

A massive industrial slag hauler, the kind used to move molten metal in steel mills. The bucket on the front still occasionally drips glowing orange material — though where it comes from is unclear. Plates of mill steel have been welded to the cab as armor. The vehicle is enormous, slow, and deeply intimidating. Built to ram. Built to last.

Signature Special Weapon

Bessemer tilts its bucket forward and pours a stream of molten slag in a line in front of him. The slag creates a damage-over-time area on the ground for 8 seconds — enemies driving through it take heavy damage and have their handling impaired by molten material sticking to their wheels. The molten slag glows orange, casting dramatic light. Best used to deny territory.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Heavy working-class accent (think Pittsburgh or Youngstown). Reserved, but fierce when provoked. Speaks of his crew as 'my men' or 'the boys.' Voice actor reference: Brian Cox or a similar gravel-voiced character actor.

Intro Cinematic (≈30s)

Open inside a steel mill, daytime, decades ago. Tony in foreman's gear stands on a catwalk watching a pour. We see his men below, working. He hears a creak. He looks up. He looks at his clipboard. He hesitates. Cut to present-day Tony in the same mill, now ruined, standing in the same spot. He has tools in his hands but isn't working. He just stands there. He hears the same creak, in memory. He climbs down to Bessemer and starts the engine. Title card: CRUCIBLE.

Ending Cinematic (≈60-90s)

Crucible wins. The Auditor stands with him on the catwalk, October 14, 2003. 'The entry has been struck.' Tony watches himself, four minutes before the collapse, give the order to evacuate. The men get out. The furnace collapses on empty floor. His men live. He drives home that night to his wife. She is happy. He is a hero in the union hall the next week. Cut to: six months later, in a different city. A different furnace. The same structural defect, in a different mill. A different foreman makes a different call. Twelve men die. Cut to: a year after that, a different mill, a different collapse, a different toll. The Auditor's voiceover, calm: 'The entry was struck from your ledger. It had to be filed somewhere else.' Tony lives the rest of his life as a hero in Ashen Hollow, reading newspapers about disasters that follow him from a distance, knowing — knowing — that he traded his own guilt for theirs. He visits a different cemetery every year on October 14th. There is always a fresh one to visit.

3.7 The Cartographer

There is a place I have dreamed of since I was a girl. It is not on any map. So I am making one.

Quick Reference

Archetype	Obsessive seeker, doomed by what she finds
Age / Occupation	38 — Geographer, professor on indefinite leave
Vehicle	1972 Plymouth Fury station wagon ('True North')
Signature Special	Triangulate
Speed	6
Armor	6
Handling	6
Special Power	6

Backstory

Dr. Eleanor Vance (no relation to the Surgeon) is a respected geographer who, in 2019, began publishing increasingly strange papers about a place she called 'the Quiet Coast.' Her colleagues assumed it was a metaphor — a kind of personal Atlantis used to illustrate the

cartographic urge. It wasn't. She had been dreaming of it since age six: a coastline of dark water, a single lighthouse, a town in the distance that she had never reached.

In 2022 she took leave from the university and began driving. She has covered 180,000 miles in three years searching for the coastline. She has narrowed it down to three possible locations. She has stopped calling her sister. She has stopped sleeping much.

The Auditor's letter contained, instead of an invitation, a partial map — and the partial map matched her notes. She believes the Auditor can complete it. She does not know that completing it is precisely the wrong thing to want.

Vehicle Design

A wood-paneled station wagon, every exterior surface covered in maps — drawn, taped, glued, layered. Some are real (USGS topographic). Some are her own (impossible coastlines, cities that aren't there). The interior is the same. The windshield is the only clear surface. Compass and astrolabe mounted to the dash, plus a working sextant that swings violently during sharp turns. Average stats across the board.

Signature Special Weapon

The Cartographer 'pins' a location on the map — placing a glowing marker on the ground. For the next 8 seconds, all her shots auto-correct slightly toward that pin (like a soft lock-on for the area, not a single target). The pin also reveals all enemy positions on the minimap as red dots regardless of line-of-sight. A utility-heavy special that rewards positional play. Cooldown: 20 seconds.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Articulate, precise, increasingly disorganized as she speaks about the Coast. Slips between academic English and dreamy, half-finished sentences. Voice actor reference: Tilda Swinton in any of her quieter roles.

Intro Cinematic (~30s)

Open in a cluttered office, walls covered in maps. Eleanor stands at a chalkboard drawing a coastline from memory. She has drawn this coastline a thousand times. She closes her eyes. We see, in her mind: dark water, a lighthouse, a town in the distance. The dream pulls away as we hear a knock on her door. The letter slides under it. She opens it. The Auditor's partial map. Her hand trembles. She gathers her keys. Title card: THE CARTOGRAPHER.

Ending Cinematic (~60-90s)

She wins. The Auditor presents her with the completed map. The Quiet Coast is a real place — specific coordinates in northern Maine. She drives there immediately. She walks the beach. It is exactly as she dreamed: the dark water, the lighthouse, the town. She is overwhelmed with relief. She walks toward the town. As she approaches, she begins to recognize details — the streets, the houses, a small graveyard at the town's edge. She walks to the graveyard. There is one fresh grave. The headstone bears her own name and a date — today's. She turns to leave. She cannot. The town's edge is now miles behind her. The lighthouse is closer. The water is rising. The Auditor's voiceover: 'You sought it. It sought you. The entry has been struck.' She

has spent her whole life trying to reach the place where she will die. Now she has. She has nowhere else to go.

3.8 The Lien

Everything in this town has a price and a due date. I just collect.

Quick Reference

Archetype	Predatory creditor who balanced his books with other people's lives
Age / Occupation	58 — Foreclosure attorney and distressed-debt buyer
Vehicle	Repossession tow truck ('Arrears')
Signature Special	Repossession
Speed	5
Armor	8
Handling	4
Special Power	7

Backstory

Silas Crane never broke a law. He read them. When the mill closed and Ashen Hollow's property values cratered, Crane bought the distressed paper — mortgages, medical debt, title loans — for cents on the dollar, then collected at full face value with interest, fees, and the full violence of the courts behind him. He was the best in three counties. He kept a ledger of his own, leather-bound, a detail the Auditor noted with something like professional courtesy.

The entry that unbalanced him: the Ardetti family. A widow, two children, a reverse-mortgage trap on the house her late husband signed without reading. Crane foreclosed in February. He had the sheriff set their belongings on the curb in eleven-degree cold, because the eviction order said 'forthwith' and forthwith was efficient. The widow, Donna Ardetti, did not go to a shelter. She went back into the emptied house that night, sealed the kitchen, and ran the car. The older child got out. The younger did not.

Crane attended neither funeral. He did, however, keep the file. He reads it the way the Warden reads Voss's. He wants the Auditor to strike the day he bought the Ardetti paper. He tells himself it's mercy. It is the first merciful thought he has ever had, and he doesn't trust it.

Vehicle Design

A repossession tow truck — a heavy flatbed wrecker with a hydraulic boom and a hook the size of a man's torso. Every flat surface is hung with the trophies of the repossessed: grandfather clocks lashed to the bed, a child's bicycle wired to the grille, wedding rings strung on a chain across the windshield like rosary beads, a wheelchair bolted to the cab roof. None of it is his. He

has never thrown anything away. The truck rides low under the weight of other people's lives. The plate reads ARREARS.

Signature Special Weapon

Crane fires the boom hook on a chain at the nearest enemy. On a hit, the hook latches and the truck reels: for 5 seconds he drains the target, siphoning one charge of their current pickup weapon to himself and bleeding HP from them into his own tank. If they carry no pickup, he takes HP and a slice of their special charge instead. The hook also tethers them, restricting how far they can pull away. A momentum-swing tool that is brutal in 1v1. Cooldown 26 seconds; 2 hook charges.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Dry, courteous, precise — the voice of a man reading you the terms you already agreed to. Never raises it. Hides behind the vocabulary of finance and law. The one time real feeling cracks through, it is appalling. Voice actor reference: the quiet menace of a Paul Giamatti antagonist.

Intro Cinematic (≈30s)

Open in a wood-paneled office, after hours, a green banker's lamp. Crane signs a stack of foreclosure orders without reading them — stamp, stamp, stamp. He pauses at one file: ARDETTI. He doesn't open it. He sets it face down and keeps stamping. Cut to him in the lot, climbing into the tow truck; the wedding rings on the windshield chain catch the streetlight. He starts the engine and the whole rig groans under its cargo. Title card: THE LIEN.

Ending Cinematic (≈60-90s)

He wins. The Auditor hands him a single sheet — the Ardetti note, the day he bought it. 'The entry has been struck.' Crane is back in his office that morning, the distressed-paper portfolio open. He crosses the Ardetti loan off the buy list. He does the merciful thing. He never owns the house; he never forecloses; Donna Ardetti and both children live. Crane feels, for the first time in his life, clean. He retires. He gives money away. He dies old, in a bed, forgiven by a town that never knew his name. Cut to: the house. Because Crane didn't buy the note, someone else did — a collections outfit with no courtroom patience and no ledger at all. They didn't wait for forthwith. The way they cleared the house was faster, and worse, and the widow and both children — both, this time — were home when it happened. The Auditor, quietly: 'Someone always holds the paper. You were, it turns out, the gentlest hand it could have fallen into.' Crane's peaceful death plays again, and we understand he never knew. He spent his whole forgiven life clean of a kindness that killed more than his cruelty ever had. The Ledger balanced. It just balanced somewhere he couldn't see. Cut to black.

3.9 Hemlock

The river remembers every drop they poured into it. So do I.

Quick Reference

Archetype	Radicalized ecologist, eco-saboteur undone by
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	collateral grief
Age / Occupation	44 — Former state hydrologist, federal whistleblower, fugitive
Vehicle	Water-district tanker ('Wormwood')
Signature Special	Bloom
Speed	3
Armor	6
Handling	5
Special Power	10

Backstory

Dr. Maren Vale was a hydrologist with the state environmental agency. She discovered that the chemical reprocessor that bought Crucible Steel's dead land had been injecting solvent waste into the aquifer beneath Ashen Hollow for years — contamination that tracked, street for street, onto a childhood-leukemia cluster in the low wards. She filed reports. They were buried. She was reassigned, then discredited, then fired; a settlement she never signed appeared bearing her forged signature.

After three years of legal dead-ends, she stopped trusting paper. She joined — then led — a cell that sabotaged the plant's pumps and pipelines until the spills became impossible to hide and the federal regulators were forced in. The campaign worked. But her last action — breaching a containment tank to flood the site with its own evidence before it could be scrubbed — released a plume into the storm drains faster than she had modeled. A maintenance crew was working a line downstream: three men, one of them barely twenty. Two lived. The youngest, Theo, drowned in chemical runoff in a culvert in the dark. She had checked the work schedule. She had the wrong week.

She has lived off-grid since, driving the stolen district tanker — once used to flush the very mains she sabotaged — full of the river's poisoned water as evidence she can no longer deliver to anyone. She believes that if she wins, the Auditor will let her unsend the team into that culvert. Give the youngest back the week.

Vehicle Design

A municipal water-district tanker truck, the kind used to flush hydrants and mains. Once white-and-green, now scabbed with rust and overtaken by living growth — kudzu, ivy, and something paler that shouldn't grow this far north. The tank doesn't carry clean water; it carries a black-green slurry drawn from the contaminated aquifer, and it weeps from every seam, leaving a glistening, killing trail. A child's hard hat, too small, hangs from the mirror. Heavy and slow; the tank's mass makes it a battering ram but a poor turner.

Signature Special Weapon

Maren opens the rear valve and lays down a wide, creeping pool of contaminated slurry around and behind the truck — a large persistent damage-over-time zone (10 seconds) that corrodes

armor, stripping effective armor from anyone who lingers, while pale, fast-growing growth erupts from it to snare wheels and cut handling. The longer an enemy stays, the worse it gets. It pairs with her low speed: she can't chase, so she poisons the ground they have to fight on. Cooldown 22 seconds.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Measured, scientific, exhausted. Quotes contamination data and half-lines of field reports the way others quote scripture. Goes very quiet, never loud, when angry. Refers to the dead boy only as 'the youngest.' Voice actor reference: Carrie Coon, lower and more tired.

Intro Cinematic (≈30s)

Open on a culvert mouth at dawn, water the color of motor oil sliding out of it. Maren stands at the lip in waders, holding a sample vial up to the gray light; the liquid inside is the same color as the water. She doesn't collect it. She just looks. Cut to her climbing into the tanker; she touches the small hard hat on the mirror, once, the way someone touches a photograph. The engine turns over wet and reluctant. The tank behind her sloshes. Title card: HEMLOCK.

Ending Cinematic (≈60-90s)

She wins. The Auditor meets her on the bank of the Ash River, clean now, silver in the sun — the way it must have looked a century ago. 'The entry has been struck.' She understands at once: the breach never happened. She is back in the third year, across a desk from a federal attorney who finally, finally believes her. No one sabotages anything. The case goes the right way — slowly. The plant fights it in court for nine years: injunctions, appeals, continued legal permitted discharge 'pending review.' Maren, vindicated and useless, watches the leukemia cluster widen ward by ward from her seat in the gallery. The boy Theo lives — grows up two streets from the plant, drinks the water every day of the childhood she preserved, and is diagnosed at nineteen. Her one act of violence, struck from the Ledger, had been the only thing that ever made them stop in time. The Auditor, gently: 'You wished to take the water back. I have. Every drop. It had to go somewhere.' Final shot: Maren, older, alone, at the same culvert — but now it runs clear, and that is so much worse. She has nothing left to carry, and nothing left to prove. The river is clean and the children are still sick and no one will ever know why. Cut to black.

3.10 The Shepherd

I counted forty souls onto that bus. The Lord only asked me for thirty-nine.

Quick Reference

Archetype	Fallen shepherd whose faith became a body count
Age / Occupation	63 — Pastor of the Hollow Light congregation
Vehicle	Congregation bus ('The Hollow Light')
Signature Special	The Flock
Speed	4

Armor	8
Handling	5
Special Power	7

Backstory

Brother Amos Teel preached on a county road outside Ashen Hollow for thirty years — a small, sincere, increasingly fervent congregation he called the Hollow Light. He was not a con man. That is the tragedy. He believed. When the mill closed and the town began to die, his sermons turned apocalyptic, and his people, who had nothing else, believed with him.

In the winter of the worst year, Teel announced a 'deliverance': he had been told, he was certain, to lead the faithful out of the dying valley in a single bus, on a single night, to high ground before a judgment that was coming. Forty people boarded. He drove them through a blizzard up the Switchback toward the reservoir, singing. The road was closed for a reason. The bus went through the guardrail and into the spillway. Teel was thrown clear into a snowbank. He was the only one. Thirty-nine drowned or froze in a county bus in the dark, singing, because he told them God said go.

The investigation called it the act of a deluded man; the survivors' families called it murder; Teel calls it obedience, and obedience is the only thing keeping him from understanding what he did. He wants the Auditor to give him back the moment at the wheel. He does not want his own life back. He wants theirs.

Vehicle Design

A short county church bus, painted with hand-lettered scripture gone illegible with rust, 'THE HOLLOW LIGHT' arcing across the side. The windows are still fogged from the inside, as if forty people were still breathing in there; in the right light, you can see handprints. The roof rack carries a salvaged church bell and a cross made of guardrail steel. The interior, glimpsed through the doors, has forty seats and forty hymnals and is always, always empty. Slow, heavy, hard to stop once moving.

Signature Special Weapon

Teel throws open the doors and preaches over a roof-mounted horn. For 6 seconds, a swarm of the faithful — pale, indistinct, singing — pours out and seeks the nearest enemies, latching onto vehicles and clawing at them for moderate damage over time while their breath and handprints fog the target's screen and obscure vision. Affected drivers also briefly drop off the minimap and lose theirs (the dead don't show on radar). A crowd-control and area-denial special that turns his congregation's death into a weapon. Cooldown 24 seconds.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Warm, resonant, a preacher's cadence that can turn from comfort to terror in a single line. Quotes scripture, but the citations are subtly wrong, as if remembered through trauma. Goes silent and very old when he stops performing. Voice actor reference: a softer Sam Elliott with a tremor underneath.

Intro Cinematic (≈30s)

Open inside the bus, in memory — warm light, forty faces, everyone singing 'Shall We Gather at the River.' Teel at the wheel, radiant, weeping with joy. He turns to look at his flock. He takes his eyes off the road. Snow fills the windshield. Cut to present: the bus on a frozen lot, dark, empty, Teel alone in the driver's seat in the cold. He can still hear the hymn, faintly. He grips the wheel. Title card: THE SHEPHERD.

Ending Cinematic (≈60-90s)

He wins. The Auditor sits in the front pew of a small country church. 'The entry has been struck.' Teel is back at the wheel on the night of the deliverance — and this time God is silent. No call comes. He doesn't start the bus. The forty go home to their cold houses. And nothing changes, because the judgment he preached was never real, and without it the Hollow Light is just forty frightened, broke people in a dying town. Over the next five winters, with no deliverance to wait for and no faith to hold them, they scatter or sicken or give up. Teel buries thirty-nine of them — the same thirty-nine — one at a time, of despair and cold and the ordinary apocalypse of a place the world abandoned. At the last funeral, the Auditor stands at the back of the church. 'You asked Me to take the night back. I did. The river was always going to have them. I only granted you the time to learn each of their names as you put them in the ground.' Teel, alone in the empty church, finally stops being able to call it obedience. The hymn plays out over black — forty voices, then thirty-nine, then one, then none.

3.11 Specter

I had eyes on for nineteen days. I knew his kids' names. Command called it a clean strike.

Quick Reference

Archetype	Remote executioner haunted by a face she watched too long
Age / Occupation	35 — Former Air Force drone sensor operator, medically discharged
Vehicle	Mobile ground-control truck ('Overwatch')
Signature Special	Danger Close
Speed	4
Armor	7
Handling	4
Special Power	9

Backstory

Staff Sergeant Dana Reyes flew nothing. She sat in an air-conditioned trailer in the high desert, eight thousand miles from the war, and watched men through a camera that could read a license plate from two miles up. For nineteen days she watched one compound, one man — a

'high-value individual.' She watched him eat, pray, carry his daughter on his shoulders, fix a motorbike. She built the pattern of life that would kill him.

On the twentieth day, command gave the order during the window the analysts liked. She lased the target; another operator pulled the trigger; the missile took eleven seconds to fall. In second nine, the children ran into the courtyard. She called the abort. Eleven seconds is not enough time. The after-action review found the strike 'lawful and proportionate.' Eighteen months later the intelligence that named him a high-value target was quietly retracted. He had been a man who fixed motorbikes.

Reyes kept the freeze-frame from second nine. She wants the Auditor to give her back those eleven seconds — to make the missile fall on empty ground.

Vehicle Design

She doesn't really drive; she operates. The 'vehicle' is a hardened mobile ground-control station — a desert-tan armored box truck bristling with antenna arrays, a satellite dome, and a Ku-band mast that sways as it moves. The windows are screens. From outside it is a slow, ugly brick; inside, glimpsed through the open rear, it is a cockpit of monitors, and Reyes drives by camera, never looking through glass. A small printed photo — a courtyard, a swing-set shadow — is taped to the corner of the center screen. Heavy, slow, poor handling. But its reach is the whole map.

Signature Special Weapon

Reyes designates a point anywhere on the arena — placeable at range, even out of line-of-sight, through her camera. A laser sparkles on the ground for a 2.5-second telegraph (not quite enough for anyone caught flat-footed to escape), then a single high-explosive strike falls from above for massive area damage. The longest-range special and the highest single hit in the game, balanced by the warning window and a long cooldown. The HUD shows the strike through her grayscale camera. Cooldown 30 seconds.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Flat, clipped, military comms cadence — 'copy,' 'good tone,' 'splash.' The flatness is armor; it cracks exactly once per match, usually right after she uses her special, when she murmurs the abort call she made too late. Voice actor reference: a hollowed-out Lauren Cohan.

Intro Cinematic (≈30s)

Open on grayscale drone-camera footage — a courtyard from above, a man, two small shapes, the crosshair drifting over them, a timer ticking in the corner. We hear Reyes's voice, flat: 'Good tone. Target acquired.' Then, half a beat too human: '...standby — standby, I have children in the — abort, abort —' The footage whites out. Cut to present: Reyes in the dark interior of the control truck, the same frozen frame on the center monitor, her face lit gray. She reaches up and taps the screen, once. The engine starts somewhere behind her. Title card: SPECTER.

Ending Cinematic (≈60-90s)

She wins. The Auditor's voice comes over her headset, not the radio: 'The entry has been struck.' She is back in the trailer, second nine, and this time the abort lands — the other

operator steers the missile wide; it falls on empty ground; the man and his daughter live. The official record shows no strike, no casualties, a clean stand-down. Reyes is discharged with a clear conscience and a commendation. She builds the life she'd written off: a husband, a house with a yard, a daughter of her own. And it is fine, for a while. Then: a summer afternoon, her daughter on a swing-set, the long shadow of the swing crossing the dirt at exactly the angle of that courtyard at midday. Reyes is at the kitchen window watching her child the way she once watched a stranger for nineteen days — and she understands that the Auditor struck the strike from the world but not from her. She still built the pattern of a man's life in order to end it. She still watched the children run in. The missile still falls, every time she closes her eyes, on the only courtyard that was ever really hers. The record is clean. She is not. The Auditor: 'I struck the entry. I could not strike the operator. You were never on the page. You were the one reading it.' Final shot: the grayscale crosshair, drifting over a child on a swing — in color now, in her own backyard. Cut to black.

3.12 Refuse

Truck's loud. Hydraulics are louder. You learn not to listen close. That was the whole job.

Quick Reference

Archetype	Ordinary man undone by an ordinary morning; the horror of autopilot
Age / Occupation	49 — Municipal sanitation worker, Route 7, twenty-six years
Vehicle	Rear-loader garbage truck ('Route 7')
Signature Special	Compaction
Speed	4
Armor	9
Handling	4
Special Power	7

Backstory

Gil Mott ran Route 7 for twenty-six years. Same streets, same cans, same dark winter mornings doing a job the city only notices when it stops. He was good at it the way you're good at anything you've stopped having to think about.

On a sub-zero morning in January, working alone and ahead of schedule, he tipped a commercial dumpster behind the shuttered bus depot into the hopper and ran the compactor, the same as ten thousand times before. There had been a sound — a soft one, under the hydraulics. He told himself it was a cat. He had told himself it was a cat about a sound every few weeks for years, and it had always been a cat or a bag or nothing. It was not a cat. A runaway, sixteen years old, named Wren, who had been sleeping in the depot dumpsters for warmth, was inside. They found out three days later.

The inquest cleared Gil completely: no way to see, no way to know, a tragedy, not a crime. Everyone agreed. Gil agreed, out loud. But he had heard the sound, and he had not stopped, because stopping was not the job and the job was the only thing that had ever asked nothing of him. He wants the Auditor to give him back the half-second when he heard it — to let him stop the cycle and look.

Vehicle Design

A municipal rear-loader garbage truck, filthy white gone gray-green, the city seal on the door scrubbed half off. The hopper at the back works — you can hear the hydraulics cycle, a wet mechanical grinding that doesn't quite stop even when the truck is idle. It always smells like January and the depot. Taped inside the cab, where a man might keep a photo of his kids, is a missing-person flyer soft with handling, a teenager's school photo on it. Enormous, slow, built to shrug off impacts — and built, at its heart, to crush.

Signature Special Weapon

Refuse activates the rear hopper. Any enemy directly behind or beside him in close range is caught by the loader arm and dragged into the compactor for a burst of heavy crushing damage and a brief stun (the grind). If no one is in range, he instead ejects a spray of compacted debris in a short cone behind him — a junk-shotgun of crushed metal and refuse that shreds light vehicles. A brutal close-range punish that rewards backing enemies into him. Cooldown 20 seconds.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Plain, flat, working-man tired. Talks about the route, the truck, the weather — anything but the depot. The one subject he can't finish a sentence about. Voice actor reference: a quieter Michael Chiklis.

Intro Cinematic (≈30s)

Open before dawn, snow, the truck's amber light turning. Gil works alone, breath fogging, the rhythm of the route — grab, tip, cycle, drive on. He tips a dumpster. He thumbs the compactor. Under the hydraulics, very faint: a sound. He pauses — half a second — hand on the lever. Then he runs the cycle and climbs back in and drives on, because that's the job. The amber light pulls away down the empty street. Title card: REFUSE.

Ending Cinematic (≈60-90s)

He wins. The Auditor stands with him behind the bus depot, that morning, snow falling. 'The entry has been struck.' Gil hears the sound again — and this time he stops the cycle. He climbs down. He looks. He finds her, half-frozen and terrified but alive, and he pulls her out and wraps her in his coat and calls it in, and a sixteen-year-old goes home. Gil is, briefly, a hero — the garbageman who saved a kid. And then the ending does the cruelest thing it can: it shows you the next morning, and the next. Gil can't stop hearing the sound now. Every dumpster. Every cycle. He stops the compactor to check, every time, on every can, because he heard it once and he was right. The route that took four hours takes nine. He's reassigned, then written up, then let go — a man who can't do the only job he ever had because he can't stop listening for the kid who isn't there anymore. He saved her by becoming a man who hears her in everything.

The girl he rescued grows up and never thinks of him again, which is exactly right, which is the whole point. The Auditor: 'You wished to hear the sound in time. You will hear it in time forever now.' Final shot: Gil, years later, in the dark cab of a truck he is no longer allowed to drive, behind the depot, listening. Cut to black.

3.13 The Bride

I was nine words from married. He never heard the other nine.

Quick Reference

Archetype	Arrested-grief devotion; frozen at the worst moment of the best day
Age / Occupation	52, dressed for 29 — Widowed at the altar, recluse
Vehicle	Stretch wedding limousine ('Honeymoon')
Signature Special	Bouquet (Till Death)
Speed	8
Armor	4
Handling	7
Special Power	5

Backstory

Imogen Ash got as far as 'I, Imogen, take thee—.' Her groom, Daniel, was twelve feet away at the front of St. Dymphna's chapel when the chandelier — original to the 1890s building, condemned along with the rest of the parish, hung anyway because Imogen wanted that church — came down. It killed him and the priest and missed Imogen by the length of a veil. She finished the sentence to a dead man because her mouth didn't know how to stop. She was twenty-nine.

She has worn the dress every day for twenty-three years. Not the same dress — she has it remade, identically, as it rots; there is a seamstress in the Tenements who has sewn the same gown eleven times and asks no questions. She kept the limousine too, the one meant to drive them away under a hail of rice. She lives in it as much as in the house.

She has rewritten the wedding ten thousand times in her head: a different church, a later date, a sentence finished. She wants the Auditor to let her finish it. To get to 'and.'

Vehicle Design

A 1990s stretch limousine, white once, now the gray of an old wedding dress left in a window. Dragged behind it on fraying ribbon: a clatter of tin cans, a single white shoe, a 'JUST MARRIED' placard with the letters mostly gone. The rear is strung with dead flowers that were fresh the morning of and have not been replaced and have not, somehow, fully crumbled. Through the windows: rice on the seats, an open ring box in the cupholder, a tuxedo jacket

folded where a passenger should be. The car is fast and light and turns like a dancer — the only graceful thing in Ashen Hollow, and the saddest.

Signature Special Weapon

Imogen tosses her bridal bouquet in a high arc onto a target area. On landing it bursts not into shrapnel but into a slow, beautiful cloud of petals and a homing 'garter' of ribbon that latches to the nearest enemy and marks them — 'caught the bouquet.' For 6 seconds the marked target takes increased damage from all sources and trails ribbon that lets everyone (including the AI) track them: the whole arena is briefly told who is next to marry the grave. A target-painting special that turns a wedding tradition into a death sentence. Cooldown 22 seconds.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Lovely, lilting, frozen in wedding-day joy — she speaks to opponents as though they are guests at her reception: delighted, gracious, completely untethered from the present. The horror is how happy she sounds. Voice actor reference: a dreamy, dissociated Cate Blanchett.

Intro Cinematic (≈30s)

Open inside the chapel, the morning of, golden light through stained glass, Imogen at the altar mid-vow, radiant, looking at someone we don't see. 'I, Imogen, take thee—' A creak above. Her smile doesn't move. Cut to black on the creak. Present: the limousine idling outside the same chapel, now condemned and dark; Imogen in the driver's seat in her gown, veil down, fresh bouquet on the dash. She lifts the veil and smiles at the rearview mirror as though at a congregation. 'Don't be nervous. Everyone's watching.' She pulls away, cans clattering. Title card: THE BRIDE.

Ending Cinematic (≈60-90s)

She wins. The Auditor waits at the altar in place of the priest. 'The entry has been struck.' Imogen is twenty-nine again, mid-vow, golden light — and this time there is no creak. She finishes the sentence: '...to be my husband.' Daniel says his. They marry. The rice falls. The limousine carries them away and she gets the and — the honeymoon, the first apartment, the ordinary years. And the ending lets her have all of it, in a warm montage that is almost merciful: a real marriage. Which means the small fights, the dull stretch in year six, the way he chewed, the affair that didn't happen but could have, the slow discovery that Daniel was a perfectly ordinary man and not the perfect husband she had spent twenty-three years building out of twelve feet and one word. She does not stop loving him. But she learns him, all the way, the way you can only learn someone you don't lose at the altar — and in learning him she loses the radiant, deathless, twelve-foot Daniel she had instead. He dies anyway, decades on, of something ordinary, an old man in a hospital, and she is an old woman at the bed, and it is sad the way all long marriages end and not transcendent at all. The Auditor, at the funeral: 'You wished to finish the sentence. You did. I cannot give you a perfect husband and a real one both. You had the perfect one for twenty-three years. You traded him for the man.' Final shot: old Imogen in ordinary widow's black for the first time in her life — the white dress gone — sitting alone, and we cannot tell whether her face holds grief or relief, and neither can she. Cut to black.

3.14 The Hunter

Opening morning. Gray light. Something moved in the brush where the deer come through. I'd been hunting forty years. I didn't miss.

Quick Reference

Archetype	Provider and predator who killed what he meant to protect
Age / Occupation	60 — Lifelong hunter, mill-town outdoorsman, father
Vehicle	Off-road hunting pickup ('First Light')
Signature Special	One in the Chamber
Speed	6
Armor	5
Handling	6
Special Power	7

Backstory

Caleb Roe taught his son Danny to hunt the way his own father taught him: patience, respect, one clean shot, never fire at what you haven't identified. Danny was nineteen, home from his first year of college a different person — quieter, taller, wearing a tan jacket Caleb didn't recognize instead of the blaze orange Caleb had bought him every year since he was eight.

Opening morning, the two of them split to walk a draw from both ends and meet in the middle, the way they had a hundred times. Caleb reached the meeting spot first. Something moved in the brush where the deer always came through — low and tan and fast in the gray half-light. Forty years of instinct, and one cardinal rule he had recited ten thousand times — be sure of your target — and the instinct won by the quarter-second it takes to break a life. He did not miss. He never missed.

He has not picked up a rifle since, except the one mounted in the truck, which he cannot bring himself to fire and cannot bring himself to sell. He wants the Auditor to give him back the quarter-second. To make himself wait. To make himself sure.

Vehicle Design

A mud-caked 1980s pickup, primer-gray and rust, a winch on the front and a gun rack in the back window holding a single rifle that is always there and never fired. Strapped across the hood, where a hunter straps a buck, is a tarp over a shape that is the wrong size and that no one ever asks about. Antlers wired to the grille. A faded blaze-orange child's cap — Danny's first, age eight — hangs from the mirror, the only bright color on the truck. Rugged, balanced, at home on broken ground; not fast, not heavy, just sure.

Signature Special Weapon

Caleb steadies and takes a single, aimed, long-range precision shot down a laser-thin sightline. It must be aimed — a brief scope-in that slows him and exposes him — and there is exactly one round, but on a hit it deals the highest single-target damage of any primary-style attack in the game, ignores a portion of armor, and staggers the target. Miss, and it's gone until the round recharges. The only true sniper tool in the roster; it rewards patience and punishes the impatient — the exact lesson he failed. Cooldown 18 seconds to recharge the single round.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Spare, Western, unhurried — a man who measures words like ammunition. Talks about wind, light, distance, the animals, the woods. Cannot say his son's name; calls him 'the boy' once and never again. Voice actor reference: a grief-worn Sam Elliott — lower than the Shepherd, no tremor, just stone.

Intro Cinematic (≈30s)

Open in gray pre-dawn woods, frost, breath. Caleb walks a draw, rifle low, calm, in his element — the one place he was ever fully himself. He reaches a clearing. Across it, brush moves — low, tan, quick. He raises the rifle in one smooth forty-year motion. The reticle settles. His finger takes up the slack. We do not see the far side. We hear the shot, and then nothing — no animal sound, just the woods going quiet the way they do after. His face changes. Cut. Present: Caleb in the truck cab at the trailhead, dawn, the unfired rifle in the rack behind his head, Danny's orange cap swinging from the mirror. He starts the engine. Title card: THE HUNTER.

Ending Cinematic (≈60-90s)

He wins. The Auditor stands with him in the gray clearing, opening morning. 'The entry has been struck.' The brush moves. And this time Caleb waits. He holds the cardinal rule. He calls out — 'Danny?' — and his son's voice comes back, annoyed and alive, 'Dad, it's me, don't shoot,' and steps out of the brush in that tan jacket, nineteen and whole. Caleb lowers the rifle with hands that won't stop shaking, and they walk out of the woods together, and Danny goes back to school and lives. Here the ending is almost kind — there is no widening disaster, just the quiet true thing the others learn the hard way. Because Caleb still raised the rifle. He waited the quarter-second this time, but he knows, and worse, the boy knows, that his father's first instinct on seeing movement where his son stood was to fire. That knowledge sits at every dinner for the rest of their lives. Danny is careful around him in a way he never used to be. He stops coming home for opening day. He stops coming home. He is alive in another city, with children Caleb sees only in photographs, and Caleb got exactly what he asked for — the boy, breathing — and lost the one thing the bullet had left him, which was a son who didn't know. The Auditor: 'You asked to be sure of your target. Now you are. So is he.' Final shot: Caleb alone at the trailhead at first light, an old man, the orange cap still on the mirror, the rifle still unfired, the passenger seat empty in a different way than before. He doesn't start the engine. Cut to black.

3.15 The Photographer

The light was perfect. That's the part no one forgives. The light was perfect and I took it.

Quick Reference

Archetype	The observer who profited from a death she didn't prevent
Age / Occupation	41 — Award-winning photojournalist, unemployable
Vehicle	Rigged press sedan ('Exposure')
Signature Special	Flashbulb
Speed	7
Armor	4
Handling	8
Special Power	5

Backstory

Mona Vane built a career on being there — first to the wreck, the fire, the flood, camera up while everyone else's hands were busy. The photograph that made her name and ended her: a famine assignment, a collapsed child, a long lens, and a choice she made in a quarter-second that she has defended in interviews and never once believed. She framed. She focused. She waited for the light. She shot. And then — she says — she helped; but the child was gone and the frame was perfect, and the frame is what survived.

It won everything. She has spent the years since unable to look at it and unable to stop looking at it. She drinks. She left the country, then the work, then the world.

She wants the Auditor to let her put the camera down in that quarter-second. To use her hands.

Vehicle Design

A boat-like 1961 sedan, black, the trunk and back seat overflowing with cameras, the roof and fenders studded with a homemade rig of giant flashbulbs strung like a string of teeth that pop and shatter when she fires. A red darkroom bulb glows in the cab. Photographs are taped across the inside of the windshield — all of them the same photograph — until she can barely see out. Fast and nimble; almost no armor; built to get there first and leave before the hands are needed.

Signature Special Weapon

Mona fires the rig — a blinding white burst that whites out the screens of all enemies in a forward arc for 2 seconds (they are 'overexposed,' driving blind) and 'develops' the nearest one, marking it on everyone's HUD as the next subject. A disorientation special that plays to her speed: blind them, reposition, strike. Cooldown 18 seconds.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Wry, deflecting, a journalist's detachment worn thin; she narrates fights like captions ('Man dies in burning car, Tuesday'). The detachment fails exactly once a match, usually as a whisper. Voice actor reference: a brittle, sardonic Robin Wright.

Intro Cinematic (≈30s)

Open in a darkroom, red light, a print surfacing in the developer tray — we never quite see it, only her face watching it bloom, lit red, unreadable. She lifts it dripping, looks at it the way you look at a wound, and pins it to a windshield already papered with copies. She climbs into the car. The flashbulb rig pops once, blinding the frame to white. Title card: THE PHOTOGRAPHER.

Ending Cinematic (≈60-90s)

She wins. The Auditor hands her a camera — hers, the one. 'The entry has been struck.' She is back in the quarter-second, lens up, light perfect, finger on the shutter. And this time she puts the camera down. She uses her hands. She gathers the child up and runs — and the ending refuses her even the certainty of whether the child lives, because the frame goes with her instead of staying, and the photograph is never taken. The image that shamed governments into moving, the one that fed a hundred thousand because two hundred million people could not look away, never exists. She saved the one child in her hands and un-saved the ones the picture would have reached. She never knows this. She only knows she dropped the camera and held a child, and she is at peace, finally, for the first time in twenty years. The horror is ours, not hers: the Auditor lets her keep her peace, and shows the audience the count. 'You wished to use your hands. You had two. The photograph had millions. I balanced it.' Final shot: Mona, old and serene, in a sunny room with no photographs on the walls, having traded the worst thing she ever did — which was also, exactly, the best — for a clean conscience she did not earn and will never question. Cut to black.

3.16 Vault

There is no wish I want granted. I came to close the Ledger.

Quick Reference

Archetype	Mystery man, anti-Auditor, possibly the previous winner
Age / Occupation	Unknown — Unknown
Vehicle	Armored car ('Iron Page')
Signature Special	Redaction
Speed	6
Armor	6
Handling	6
Special Power	6

Backstory

Vault is unlocked after completing all fifteen standard endings. His backstory is revealed across the campaign through hidden audio logs.

Vault was once a contestant in the previous Black Ledger tournament, ten years prior. He won. He made his wish. He learned what we have learned — that wishes are debts and the Ledger always balances. His wish, whatever it was, destroyed his life. But unlike the others, he did not accept it. He spent the next ten years studying the Auditor — finding the previous tournaments (every decade for centuries), finding the previous winners (all of whom died young, broken). He learned that the Auditor is not a person but a process. He learned the rules.

He has returned to compete again. He is the only contestant who cannot be granted a wish — he has already had his — and so he cannot be undone. He is here to close the Ledger permanently.

His face is never shown. We never learn his real name. The official record of the previous tournament's winner does not exist; the Auditor erased him from history as part of his wish.

Vehicle Design

A modified armored cash-transport vehicle, jet black, no markings, windows blacked out from outside but appearing normal from inside. Heavy front-mounted ram. The vehicle is reinforced in a way that doesn't match any visible armor plating — as if it is heavier on the inside than the outside, somehow. Solid stats with no glaring weaknesses; this is a 'mastery' character.

Signature Special Weapon

Vault fires a black ink projectile that, on hit, 'redacts' the target — they appear in solid black on Vault's screen but, more importantly, are unable to use their special weapon for 12 seconds. Targets affected by Redaction lose access to their unique ability — a devastating counter to any character whose kit relies on their special. Cooldown: 30 seconds.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Modulated, deliberately disguised. Speaks rarely; when he does, he speaks the truth. Voice actor reference: think a quieter, sadder version of any iconic 'mystery man' voice.

Intro Cinematic (~30s)

Vault has no intro cinematic. He simply appears on the roster after the fifteenth ending. Selecting him plays a montage of cryptic images: a different tournament, in a different decade. A different city, equally dying. A man in a charcoal suit. A figure in black walking away from a burning building, then climbing into the armored car. Title card: VAULT.

Ending Cinematic (~60-90s)

Vault wins the tournament. The Auditor sits across from him. 'You knew the cost. You knew you could not be paid.' Vault speaks for the first time: 'I came to balance the Ledger.' He places his hand on the book. Pages tear themselves free — every contestant's page, blank now. The Auditor's form flickers. The Auditor was never a person; he was the Ledger's enforcement mechanism, and the Ledger has been closed. The flicker grows. The Auditor smiles, faintly, for the first time. 'Then I am free as well.' He dissipates. Vault stands alone in Ashen Hollow. The streetlights stop flickering. The radio stations resume normal broadcast. Vault drives out of the city. We follow Iron Page down a road lit by dawn. He does not look back. In the distance, behind him, the city is empty and at peace. Cut to credits.

Design Notes

Vault is the New Game+ unlock and represents the 'true ending.' He has no personal cutscenes in the campaign — only audio logs scattered across all fifteen other campaigns. Completing all of them is the only way to piece together his story. His final ending is the only one where the Auditor is defeated through closing the Ledger rather than inheriting it; this is intentional. He is the player's reward for caring about every other character. (Note: this is a distinct ending from defeating the Auditor in combat as a standard contestant — see Section 6.10. Vault closes the book; everyone else, at most, takes over keeping it.)

4. WEAPONS & COMBAT

4.1 Weapon Categories

- Primary Fire (unlimited ammo, low damage): the always-available baseline. Each vehicle has its own visual flavor but is mechanically similar.
- Pickup Weapons (limited ammo, varied effects): the core tactical layer. Found on the map. All characters use the same pickup pool.
- Signature Special (cooldown-based, unique per character): the identity-defining ability. Already detailed in Section 3.
- Environmental Hazards: not player-controlled, but exploitable. Detailed in Section 5.

4.2 Primary Fire

Each vehicle's primary fire fits its theme but mechanically falls into one of three categories. This keeps balance manageable across the roster.

Type	Fire Rate	Damage	Range	Best Suited For
Rapid (Machine Gun)	Fast	Low	Medium	Pressure, suppression
Burst (Auto Shotgun)	Medium	Medium	Short	Brawler vehicles
Heavy (Cannon)	Slow	High	Long	Tanks and snipers

4.3 Pickup Weapons (Launch Roster)

Fourteen pickups spawn around every arena — thirteen weapons plus the all-important Health Pack. All characters draw from the same shared pool; what you find is what you fight with. (v0.3 added six new pickups to v0.1's eight: the Spike Strip, Concussion Charge, Arc Lance, Process Server, Effigy, and Final Notice — chosen to fill tactical niches the original pool left open: zoning, knockback, sustained fire, deployables, misdirection, and a contested 'finisher'.)

Weapon	Ammo	Effect	Rarity
Homing Missile	3 ammo	Locks onto the nearest enemy in front of the player. Moderate damage, decent tracking. The bread-and-butter offensive pickup.	Common
Power Missile	2 ammo	Straight-line unguided missile. High damage.	Common

		Slow, easy to dodge, but devastating on hit. Best when targets are pinned.	
Ricochet	4 ammo	Bounces off walls up to three times before exploding. Excellent in tight arenas, useless in open ones.	Uncommon
Remote Bomb	2 ammo	Drops a bomb behind the vehicle that detonates on a delay or on a second press of the fire button. Trap warfare.	Uncommon
Freeze Missile	1 ammo	Encases target in ice for 3 seconds. They cannot move, but they take no damage. Setup for a power missile combo.	Rare
EMP	1 ammo	Disables target's HUD, lock-ons, and special for 4 seconds. Counter to special-spam strategies.	Rare
Napalm	1 ammo	Lobbed arc; on impact creates a fire zone that lingers for 6 seconds. Area denial.	Rare
Spike Strip	3 ammo	Deploys a spread of scavenged spikes and rebar behind the vehicle. Anyone who drives over the field takes light damage and suffers badly degraded handling and top speed for 4 seconds (shredded tires). Cuts off pursuers and locks down chokepoints; useless head-on.	Uncommon
Concussion Charge	2 ammo	A 360-degree	Uncommon

		pressure blast centered on the vehicle ('Backdraft'). Minor damage, but it violently knocks back and briefly staggers every vehicle in close range, scattering swarms and interrupting specials mid-cast. The panic button — peel off attackers or blow apart a pile-up.	
Arc Lance	1 ammo (sustained)	A salvaged industrial cutting torch. A short-to-medium tether that must be held on target; damage ramps the longer line-of-sight is maintained, melting through armor. Punishing to aim while driving, devastating once mastered — the roster's only sustained-beam weapon.	Rare
Process Server	1 ammo	Drops a jury-rigged auto-turret that bolts to the ground and fires on any enemy in range for 8 seconds before burning out. Forces enemies out of a zone and guards a pickup or a flank; can be gunned down by focused fire.	Rare
Effigy	2 ammo	Projects a flickering phantom duplicate of your vehicle that peels away on its own. Enemy lock-ons, homing missiles, and AI targeting all prefer	Uncommon

		the effigy for 5 seconds. Break a missile lock, bait a special, vanish.	
Final Notice	1 ammo	Rare power pickup ('Foreclosure'); roughly one contested spawn per match. Releases a single slow, glowing seeker bearing the Auditor's seal that locks one target and pursues relentlessly — it cannot be outrun, only broken by hard line-of-sight or obstacles. On contact, catastrophic damage. The debt always comes due.	Rare
Health Pack	Restores 33% HP	Not a weapon; the most important pickup on the map. Spawns rotate between fixed locations.	Common

4.4 Combat Feel — Non-Negotiables

These are not features. These are the difference between a game that feels good and one that doesn't. They are required across the board.

- Hit-stop: every projectile impact freezes the engine for 50-100ms. This sells weight.
- Screen shake: scaled to weapon — small for primary fire, large for power missile, massive for character-special hits.
- Audio layering: every impact has at least three layers — the projectile sound, the impact crunch, and the debris/particle sound. Mix all three.
- Damage feedback: vehicles show damage progressively (paint scrapes → dents → broken windows → smoke → fire). Visual state is always synced with HP.
- Death moment: when a vehicle dies, time slows by 30% for 1 second. The kill camera lingers on the explosion.

4.5 Health & Damage Numbers (Starting Point)

Specific numbers will be tuned during playtesting. These are starting values for the prototype.

- Base vehicle HP: 1000. Armor stat 1-10 multiplies effective HP from 0.7x to 1.5x.

- Primary fire damage: 5-12 per shot (varies by type).
- Homing missile: 80 damage on direct hit, 40 splash.
- Power missile: 200 damage on direct hit, 60 splash.
- Specials: 100-250 damage range, with non-damage utility specials valued accordingly.
- Average kill time: 10-15 seconds of sustained combat (not a one-shot game, not a HP-sponge game).

4.6 Boss Combat (v0.2)

Each of the ten arenas is gated by a Collector boss (Section 6). These fights are the difficulty spikes of the campaign and must feel like the Twisted Metal boss fights players remember — hard, tense, and fair. The following rules apply to every Collector.

- HP: bosses carry 3x-6x a standard vehicle's effective HP, distributed across phases rather than one long bar.
- Phases: every boss has three phases, triggered at HP thresholds (roughly 66% and 33%). Each phase adds or escalates an attack so the fight evolves rather than repeats.
- Tells and windows: every major boss attack has a clear visual or audio tell (a wind-up, a light change, a sound), and every boss has a recurring vulnerability window — a recovery beat after a heavy attack when it can be punished. No unavoidable damage, no cheap deaths. Difficulty comes from execution and reading the boss, not from randomness.
- Arena weaponization: each boss turns its arena's signature environmental hazard (Section 5) against the player and is usually immune to it.
- Adds: some bosses summon minion vehicles. Adds exist to pressure positioning, never to overwhelm; cap on-screen adds so the player can always make progress on the boss.
- Difficulty options: bosses scale with the game's difficulty setting via HP, attack frequency, and tell-window length — never by removing tells. Accessibility settings can lengthen tells without trivializing the fight.
- Reward: defeating a Collector for the first time on any save permanently unlocks it as a playable character (Section 6).

5. ARENAS

Ten arenas, all within Ashen Hollow. Each is themed around an aspect of the city's decline, and each is held by a Collector boss whose fight ends that arena's campaign chapter (Section 6). Every arena must have: at least one signature environmental hazard, multiple verticality options (ramps, lower levels, rooftops), pickup spawns balanced for the layout, and a thematic 'centerpiece' that defines the arena visually.

5.1 The Mill

Theme	The abandoned Crucible Steel mill, the heart of Ashen Hollow's decline.
Layout	Large open central floor with overhead catwalks (skill-based shortcut for fast vehicles), three furnace pits, and surrounding loading bays. Multiple verticality levels.
Signature Hazard	Furnace pours — every 90 seconds a random furnace lights up and pours molten slag onto the floor in a predictable pattern. 5 seconds of warning (steam vents hiss, lights flash orange). Vehicles caught take massive damage.
Pickup Density	High — 12 spawn points. This is the 'casual fun' arena.
Atmosphere	Industrial gothic. Orange light through rust. Distant clanging.
Collector	The Foundryman — “Tap” (Section 6.1).

Destructible & Interactive Features

Tap the Ladle — A massive slag ladle hangs from a crane over the central floor. Shoot out its release pins and it tips, dumping a wave of molten metal that turns the main floor into a temporary lethal zone — then the emptied ladle drops on its chain to hang as a swinging steel hazard and improvised cover for the rest of the match.

Collapse the Catwalks — Concentrated fire on the overhead catwalk supports brings the whole gantry network crashing down. The fast-vehicle shortcut is gone for good — but the wreckage settles into a debris ramp from the floor up to a surviving section of gantry, opening high ground that wasn't reachable before.

Blow the Furnace — Each furnace has glowing pressure valves. Pump enough rounds into them and the furnace detonates once, catastrophically — gutting that corner of the mill, killing anything close, and blasting a hole through the exterior wall into a sealed loading bay, permanently adding a new room to the arena.

5.2 Ashen Hollow Downtown

Theme	The half-condemned city center. Storefronts boarded up, traffic lights still blinking out of sync.
Layout	Urban grid with multiple parallel streets, intersections, alleyways for ambushes, and one collapsed building forming a ramp to second-story rooftops.
Signature Hazard	Sinkholes — the streets are unstable. Three intersections have visible cracks. A random one collapses each match (warning: rumbling for 4 seconds), creating a permanent pit for that match.
Pickup Density	Medium — 8 spawn points. Encourages aggressive driving.
Atmosphere	Wet asphalt, sodium-vapor streetlights, perpetual drizzle. Empty city loneliness.
Collector	Curfew (Section 6.2).

Destructible & Interactive Features

Drop the Water Tower — The rooftop water tower leans on rusted legs over Main Street. Shoot them out and it crashes down across the avenue, forming a ramp up onto the second-story rooftops — opening an entire elevated rooftop battlefield above the grid. This map's signature transformation.

Rupture the Gas Main — Shooting the exposed gas coupling at the central intersection ignites a roaring line of flame jets down the street (a timed lethal corridor); the blast then caves the road into a fresh sinkhole, opening a shortcut down into the storm drains below.

Facade Demolition — Plate-glass storefronts and a parking deck line the streets as destructible cover. Enough damage drops a building facade into the road, creating a wall of rubble that blocks a lane and rewrites the sightlines for the rest of the match.

5.3 The Tenements

Theme	A collapsed apartment block, half the buildings condemned and partially demolished.
Layout	Tight, claustrophobic. Narrow streets between high walls. Lots of cover. Two interior spaces (a parking garage and a partially-standing building's first floor).
Signature Hazard	Falling debris — every 30 seconds, masonry falls from one of the buildings. Audio cue (creaking, then crash) gives 2 seconds of

	warning. High damage to vehicles directly underneath.
Pickup Density	Low — 6 spawn points, but more powerful pickups. Encourages careful positioning over chaos.
Atmosphere	Brutalist horror. Graffiti, broken windows, occasional movement in the upper-floor darkness that may or may not be real.
Collector	Condemned (Section 6.3).

Destructible & Interactive Features

Pancake the Tower — Detonate the propane tanks ringing the base of the tallest condemned tenement and it comes down lengthwise across the alley grid — crushing anything beneath, then laying the fallen building down as a rubble ramp you can climb onto its tilted, open-roomed floors. A new elevated maze grows out of the collapse.

Garage Collapse — Shoot the support columns inside the parking structure to drop its upper deck. The interior is sealed off, but the parked wrecks spill out into the street as scattered cover, reshaping the choke.

Tear Down the Scaffolding — Webs of scaffolding, clotheslines, and hanging sheets block the sightlines between the high walls. Shredding them strips away the soft cover and blows the claustrophobic alleys wide open — a risk/reward call for snipers.

5.4 Highway 6 Overpass

Theme	A stretch of elevated interstate, frozen mid-construction when the city's funding collapsed.
Layout	Long and linear with a wide central spine. Two levels — the highway itself and the abandoned construction below. Falling off either edge is instant death (no respawn).
Signature Hazard	Wind — sudden gusts (every 45-60 seconds, randomized) push light vehicles toward the edges. Sound cue: rising whistle for 2 seconds before the gust. Heavy vehicles barely affected; light vehicles must compensate.
Pickup Density	Medium — 8 spawn points, but spread across two levels.
Atmosphere	Endless gray sky. Distant cars on a parallel highway that never come closer. The illusion of escape that isn't real.
Collector	Jackknife (Section 6.4).

Destructible & Interactive Features

Blow the Span — The central support pier is visibly cracked. Destroy it and a section of the upper highway drops onto the abandoned construction level below — creating a ramp that finally links the two levels (and a gap up top you have to jump). The map's defining transformation.

Cut the Crane — A frozen tower crane hangs its boom over the highway. Sever the counterweight cable and the boom swings free, sweeping the deck and flinging anything in its path off the edge — then settles as a girder bridge out to an isolated side platform stacked with pickups.

Release the Cargo — Stalled flatbeds loaded with pipe and rebar line the shoulder. Shoot out their tie-down straps to unleash a rolling avalanche of steel down the lanes — a sweeping hazard you can time against a pursuer.

5.5 The Cemetery

Theme	Hollow Hill Cemetery, where every contestant has been before. (The names on the stones are characters' names if you stop to read them.)
Layout	Sprawling open ground with rolling hills. Mausoleums provide cover. A central church (interior accessible) is a strategic high-ground position.
Signature Hazard	Fog — visibility drops to ~50 meters for 20 seconds at a time (every 90 seconds). The minimap still works; line-of-sight does not. Encourages homing-weapon use during fog.
Pickup Density	Medium — 10 spawn points, mostly clustered around the mausoleums.
Atmosphere	Cold, blue, silent. The only arena with no diegetic music — only wind.
Collector	The Sexton (Section 6.5).

Destructible & Interactive Features

Topple the Bell Tower — Bring down the church bell tower and it falls across the graveyard as a stone causeway up onto the church roof — opening commanding new high ground — while the great bronze bell breaks loose and rolls the grounds as a moving hazard.

Crack the Crypts — The mausoleums are destructible. Blasting one open spills a pickup cache but collapses into a pit; breaching the largest family crypt opens a stairway down into a catacomb tunnel network that secretly links opposite ends of the map.

Open Ground — Rain-saturated grave plots give way under weight and explosions. Heavy vehicles and blasts subside the soft earth into shallow graves, bogging down anything that lingers and slowly deforming the terrain over the match.

5.6 The Auditor's Office

Theme	Final arena. Not a real place. A non-Euclidean space the Auditor manifests for the final fights — endless filing cabinets, towering bookshelves, papers drifting through the air.
Layout	Surreal — paths shift mid-match. Three 'rooms' connected by doorways that occasionally re-route to different rooms. Pickup spawns are unpredictable.
Signature Hazard	Reality glitches — every 60 seconds, the geometry briefly reshuffles. Visible effect: papers swirl, lights flicker, doorways change destination. Doesn't damage but forces re-planning.
Pickup Density	High but unpredictable — 12 spawn points that move between fights.
Atmosphere	Dread. Silence broken only by the rustle of papers. Distant typewriter sounds. The Auditor's voice occasionally narrates from above.
Collector	The Auditor himself — the final fight (Section 6.10).

Destructible & Interactive Features

Pull the Stacks — The towering filing stacks and bookshelves are destructible. Topple one and it crushes whatever is beneath, then falls to bridge an otherwise unreachable mezzanine — though a reality glitch may 're-file' it and reset the change, so use the window while it lasts.

Open a Drawer of the Ledger — Giant filing-cabinet drawers line the walls. Shoot the wrong one and it slams out as a battering hazard; shoot the right one and it slides open into a shortcut passage between rooms — a rare bit of routing you control in a map that usually routes itself.

Spill the Ink — Pool-sized inkwells of the Auditor's red ink sit throughout the Office. Rupture one and it floods the room, redacting the HUD and vision of anything that drives through and slicking the floor — a player-made dose of the dread the map runs on.

5.7 The Drowned Quarter

Theme	The lowest district of Ashen Hollow, where the Ash River was dammed and then poisoned. Half-submerged streets, a flooded chapel, the contamination Maren Vale died trying to expose.
Layout	A sunken grid at two water levels — shallow

	flats you can drive (slowed) and deep channels that are death. Rooftops and a half-submerged church steeple form the high-ground centerpiece; a failing dam and spillway run along one edge.
Signature Hazard	Tidal Surge — every ~75 seconds the failing dam releases a wall of toxic water that sweeps the low streets from one telegraphed direction (klaxon and rising roar, 4-second warning). Vehicles caught in the deep surge take massive damage and are shoved; standing in toxic water is a constant light damage-over-time. High ground is safe.
Pickup Density	Medium — 8 spawn points, the best ones on rooftops and the steeple (risk/reward verticality).
Atmosphere	Drowned and green-black. Oil-sheen rainbows on dead water, a church bell tolling underwater, things floating you don't look at twice.
Collector	Undertow (Section 6.6).

Destructible & Interactive Features

Breach the Dam — The cracked dam face can be blown open early. Doing so unleashes a permanent flood that raises the water a full level — drowning the low streets for good and forcing the entire fight up onto the rooftops and the steeple. The arena's defining transformation: it takes the ground away and lifts the war into the air.

Drop the Steeple — Topple the half-submerged church steeple so it falls across the channels as a precarious bridge, linking two rooftop clusters over water that would otherwise kill you.

Cut the Moorings — Massive debris mats — shipping containers, a capsized barge — float the channels on rusted moorings. Shoot a mooring loose and the mat drifts free, becoming a moving platform and cover that slides across the water.

5.8 The Switchyard

Theme	The Conrail interchange that once carried Crucible Steel's freight, now a rusting maze of dead track, stacked boxcars, and one train that still runs though no one drives it.
Layout	A sprawling rail yard — long sightlines down parallel tracks (sniper heaven), cover from boxcars and gantry cranes, stackable verticality on container piles, and a roundhouse interior.

	Tracks crisscross the entire arena.
Signature Hazard	The Ghost Train — every ~60 seconds a headlight appears at one end and a runaway train barrels down a randomly chosen track (horn blast, light, and rumble give 3 seconds' warning). Instant kill on the track; the smart play is knowing which rails are hot.
Pickup Density	Medium-High — 10 spawn points, several tucked between cars and on the container stacks.
Atmosphere	Iron and ozone. Endless rows of dead cars, a signal that still clicks red-green to no one, the far-off horn of a train that has no business running.
Collector	Lodestone (Section 6.7).

Destructible & Interactive Features

Throw the Switch — Track switches sit at the junctions. Ram or shoot a switch lever to re-route the Ghost Train onto a different line — turning the map's runaway-train hazard into a weapon you can aim at an enemy.

Topple the Stacks — The stacked shipping containers are destructible. Blow out a base container and the stack collapses — fall it one way for a wall of cover that blocks a lane, the other way for a ramp up onto the gantry walkway and new high ground.

Drop the Gantry Crane — Sever the legs of the overhead gantry crane and the entire structure crashes down across the yard — crushing anything beneath as it falls, then spanning several tracks as a massive steel bridge: a new elevated crossing over the killing rails.

5.9 Pinewood Drive-In & Fairground

Theme	A roadside drive-in theater and the traveling carnival that set up in its lot in 1991 and never tore down — rides rusted mid-spin, the great screen still flickering the Auditor's footage.
Layout	An open central lot (the drive-in field, speaker poles as obstacles) ringed by carnival attractions — a Ferris wheel, a carousel, a funhouse and tilt-a-whirl you can drive through, a midway of game booths. The screen anchors one end; the rides serve as cover and verticality (ramps up the wrecked coaster track).
Signature Hazard	The Rides Wake Up — every ~80 seconds a random attraction activates: the Ferris wheel

	sheds a gondola that rolls across the lot, the carousel flings debris in a widening circle, or a coaster car comes off its track. Telegraphed by the ride lurching to life (calliope stutters on, lights flicker; 3-4 second warning).
Pickup Density	High — 12 spawn points scattered down the midway. The 'fun and chaotic' arena, by deliberate, sick contrast.
Atmosphere	Sun-faded primary colors gone sinister. A calliope playing a half-step flat. The screen showing grayscale footage of the contestants themselves, from angles no camera was at. Cotton candy and rust.
Collector	The Headliner — “Mr. Marrow” (Section 6.8).

Destructible & Interactive Features

Fell the Ferris Wheel — Shoot out the Ferris wheel's support legs and the whole wheel tears free, rolls across the lot as a giant rolling hazard, and crashes down — its spokes and gondolas settling into a climbable structure up to a new vantage point. Pure Eiffel-Tower energy: the wreck becomes the playground.

Drop the Screen — Topple the giant drive-in screen and it falls flat across the field as an enormous ramp and raised platform — opening a whole new plane to fight on, after one last blinding white flare.

Derail the Coaster — Hit the coaster's lift-hill mechanism to send a runaway car screaming around the track as a circuiting hazard — until it flies off at the broken section and smashes a hole into the funhouse, opening that interior to traffic.

5.10 Saint Dymphna's

Theme	Ashen Hollow State Hospital — 'Saint Dymphna's,' the asylum on the far side of Hollow Hill, where the town sent what it couldn't look at. Closed in 1994, never emptied.
Layout	A claustrophobic interior arena — long ward corridors, a flooded basement (hydrotherapy), a central rotunda with a collapsed skylight (the only natural light and the one open vertical space), barred day-rooms as kill-boxes. Tight, dark, cover-heavy.
Signature Hazard	Arc & Collapse — the dead electrical system surges: every ~50 seconds, exposed wiring and the flooded floors arc with current in a spreading, telegraphed pattern (lights buzz up

	bright, 2-second warning) for heavy damage; occasionally a water-logged ceiling section collapses instead. Two hazards on one timer keep players reading the room.
Pickup Density	Low — 6 spawn points, but powerful ones, deep in the dangerous interior. Rewards nerve over greed.
Atmosphere	Institutional green tile and dark. Wheelchairs that have rolled to the low corners on their own. A PA that still pages doctors who died decades ago.
Collector	The Alienist (Section 6.9).

Destructible & Interactive Features

Bring Down the Rotunda — The central dome already sags around a collapsed skylight. Finish its cracked support ring and the rest of the ceiling comes down — raining masonry once, then opening the roof to the sky and leaving a debris mound that ramps up to a new rooftop vantage above the wards.

Flood the Lower Ward — Burst the rusted valves and pipes from the hydrotherapy basement to flood a ward, raising water up into the corridor. It becomes a lethal trap whenever the building's electrical arc hazard fires — a kill-zone you can set up and herd enemies into.

Breach the Wards — The interior partition walls and barred day-room cages are destructible. Blasting through them opens fresh shortcuts between corridors, turning the claustrophobic kill-boxes into an open, navigable floor on your terms.

6. THE COLLECTIONS — BOSSES

Every contestant who enters the Black Ledger and loses still owes. The Auditor does not waste a debt. The losers of past tournaments — the ones who didn't die of their wishes because they never earned one — are bound to Ashen Hollow as the Ledger's enforcement: the Collections. Each one haunts a single arena, balancing accounts for an employer it can never pay off.

They are not bound by the contestants' 24-point stat budget; decades of collecting have made them monstrous. Each map's campaign chapter ends with its Collector (combat rules in Section 4.6). Beat one, and the Auditor — scrupulous about debts owed to him as well as by him — signs its contract over to you: the Collector is freed, and its vehicle joins your roster, still bearing the Auditor's seal, still overpowered, a trophy that was once a person.

Defeating all ten is the long road. The short road — Vault — remains for those who would rather close the book than collect it (Section 3.16).

Boss stat note: the numbers below intentionally exceed 24 (most total 28-34). As playable unlocks, Collectors keep these boss-tier stats — they are deliberately game-breaking 'mastery' picks, marked in the roster with the Auditor's seal and excluded from any future balanced or ranked mode. The Auditor (6.10) has no honest stats at all.

6.1 The Foundryman — “Tap”

Heat doesn't forgive. It just waits for you to slow down.

Quick Reference

Bound to	The Mill (5.1)
Vehicle	Self-propelled torpedo-ladle car ('Cupola')
Boss Special	Tap the Heat
Speed	2
Armor	14
Handling	2
Special Power	10
Stat Total	28 (exceeds the 24 budget by design)
Class	Immovable juggernaut / fire control

Backstory

A contestant two tournaments ago — a furnace tapper at a mill in another dying city who wished to 'burn away' his debts. He lost. The Auditor read the wish literally and bound him to the heat he loved: now he is the man and the furnace both. He has forgotten his name. He remembers temperature.

Vehicle Design

A torpedo ladle car — the cigar-shaped rail vessel that carries molten iron — mounted on a crawler chassis, glowing from within through cracks in its refractory shell. Where a cab would be sits a cage of mill steel with something man-shaped and incandescent inside. It leaves scorch tracks. The plate, half-melted, reads CUPOLA.

Boss Special & Fight Design

Three-phase fight in The Mill, with huge HP. Phase 1: he lumbers and slams, his primary attack a directed molten spray (the arena's furnace-pour hazard, but aimed). Phase 2 (66%): he taps the arena's furnaces on command — the map's pour hazard fires twice as often and he is immune to it. Phase 3 (33%): his shell cracks; he overheats, gaining speed and leaving a permanent fire trail, but exposing a glowing core (his weak point) for 3 seconds after each big slam. Window: bait the slam, hit the core. Tell: the cage doors glow white before every pour.

Voice & Dialogue Style

A furnace roar with words in it; speaks in temperatures and pours, never names.

Fight Intro

The Mill's center furnace lights without warning; the floor floods orange; Cupola rises through the slag like a ship surfacing. 'You're early for the pour.'

On Defeat — Playable Unlock

His shell goes dark; the man-shape inside finally cools, exhales decades of heat, and is gone. The Auditor signs Cupola over to you. Playable: a max-armor, near-immovable juggernaut whose special, 'Tap the Heat,' lays a budget-breaking wall of molten slag — like Crucible's Pour, but bigger and hotter. The slowest, hardest-to-kill thing in the game.

6.2 Curfew

Streets are closed. They've been closed since the order. You just didn't read it.

Quick Reference

Bound to	Ashen Hollow Downtown (5.2)
Vehicle	Armored riot-control truck ('Order')
Boss Special	Backup
Speed	5
Armor	10
Handling	4
Special Power	11
Stat Total	30 (exceeds the 24 budget by design)
Class	Summoner bruiser / zone control

Backstory

A police chief from a past tournament who wished a scandal away — a cover-up, a kid dead in custody, a town that almost burned. He lost. The Auditor made him the law he hid behind: now he is the curfew itself, patrolling a downtown that empties when his lights turn. He cannot remember the kid's name. That is the punishment.

Vehicle Design

An armored riot-control truck — a BearCat-type rig with a roof water cannon (now spraying scalding industrial runoff), a wall of riot shields welded to the front, and a PA tower. Its light bar washes the whole arena red-and-blue. The plate reads ORDER.

Boss Special & Fight Design

Phase 1: he calls 'units' — derelict, driverless squad-car adds (two or three at a time) that ram and explode while the water cannon sweeps for area denial. Phase 2 (50%): 'CURFEW IS IN EFFECT' — his PA inverts the arena: streetlights go red, standing still in cover is safe, but moving in the open draws automated spotlight-fire. Adds keep coming. Window: he's vulnerable while the water cannon is committed (long recovery). Tell: the light bar strobes white before a spotlight sweep.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Calm dispatcher cadence over a PA; everything sounds like a routine traffic stop until it isn't.

Fight Intro

Every traffic light in Downtown snaps to red at once. A searchlight finds you. 'Vehicle. Step out of the vehicle. ...No? They never do.'

On Defeat — Playable Unlock

His lights die; the streets, for the first time in decades, are just empty, not forbidden. The Auditor signs ORDER over to you. Playable: a summoner bruiser — special 'Backup' deploys a pair of kamikaze squad-car drones that hunt the nearest enemy. Budget-breaking because you fight three-on-one in your favor.

6.3 Condemned

Everything standing is just waiting for permission to fall. I'm the permission.

Quick Reference

Bound to	The Tenements (5.3)
Vehicle	Lattice-boom wrecking crane ('Eminent Domain')
Boss Special	Bring It Down
Speed	3
Armor	11
Handling	3

Special Power	12
Stat Total	29 (exceeds the 24 budget by design)
Class	Arena-destroyer / battlefield control

Backstory

A demolition contractor and slumlord from a past tournament who wished away a building collapse he'd cut corners on — a tenement fire-escape that pancaked with people on it. He lost. The Auditor gave him dominion over collapse: he brings buildings down now, on command, forever, and can never stop, because stopping would mean standing still long enough to remember who was on the fire escape.

Vehicle Design

A demolition crane-truck — a mobile lattice-boom crane with a wrecking ball and a clamshell grapple, draped in caution tape and condemned notices, dust-caked. The ball swings on its own between attacks. The plate reads EMINENT DOMAIN.

Boss Special & Fight Design

He weaponizes the map's falling-debris hazard. Phase 1: wrecking-ball melee (a huge arc, telegraphed by the ball winding up) and lobbed masonry. Phase 2 (60%): he begins collapsing the arena — designating a building (red dust, groaning, 4-second tell) and bringing it down, permanently removing that cover and creating a kill-zone; the arena shrinks as the fight goes on. Phase 3 (30%): nowhere left to hide; he's faster and the grapple can grab and throw you into the next collapse. Window: after a ball-swing the crane over-rotates and the cab is exposed. Tell: the ball winds back; dust plumes mark the next building.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Bored, municipal — the voice of a man reading a demolition permit. Counts down: '...and she comes down in three, two...'

Fight Intro

A condemned notice flutters onto your windshield. Above you, the tallest tenement groans. 'Signed, sealed. You're standing in the footprint.'

On Defeat — Playable Unlock

The dust settles; the last wall he was about to drop stays up. The Auditor signs EMINENT DOMAIN over to you. Playable: a zone-control monster — special 'Bring It Down' collapses a chunk of any arena into a damaging rubble field. Budget-breaking battlefield control.

6.4 Jackknife

Eighteen wheels, no brakes, and a schedule I will never, ever make.

Quick Reference

Bound to	Highway 6 Overpass (5.4)
Vehicle	Cab-over semi with flaming tanker trailer ('Long Way Down')
Boss Special	Jackknife
Speed	9
Armor	12
Handling	3
Special Power	9
Stat Total	33 (exceeds the 24 budget by design)
Class	Fast heavyweight / ram terror

Backstory

A long-haul trucker from a past tournament who wished away the wreck he caused running on no sleep to make a delivery window — a family's minivan, a rainy night, a curve he took too fast. He lost. The Auditor put him back on the road forever, hauling a load he'll never deliver, on a highway that goes nowhere, unable to stop, because stopping is the one thing he didn't do.

Vehicle Design

A black cab-over semi dragging a flaming tanker trailer, chrome bull-bar grille, headlights like a thing's eyes, an air horn that sounds like a scream. The trailer jackknifes on command, sweeping the road. The plate reads LONG WAY DOWN.

Boss Special & Fight Design

Staged on the linear, two-level, edges-are-death Overpass — the perfect boss arena. Phase 1: high-speed charges down the spine; you dodge and shoot the exposed rear tanker while he uses the map's wind gusts to shove you toward the edges. Phase 2 (50%): jackknife sweeps — he slams the trailer across the full width of the highway (telegraphed by air-brake hiss and the trailer swinging wide), forcing you to the very edge or under it on the lower level; the trailer leaks fire. Phase 3 (25%): full fury — he stops charging in straight lines and starts trying to ram you off the overpass entirely, trailer fully ablaze. Window: after a jackknife the trailer takes a beat to straighten — burn the tanker. Tell: air horn and brake hiss before every jackknife.

Voice & Dialogue Style

CB-radio rasp, all road-talk and mile markers, increasingly unhinged about the schedule.

Fight Intro

Headlights fill your mirrors from nowhere on a road you thought was empty. The air horn screams. 'MOVE. I am NOT stopping. I have NEVER been able to stop.'

On Defeat — Playable Unlock

The rig finally jackknifes for good and burns itself out against the barrier; the cab door opens and no one gets out, but the schedule, at last, is cancelled. The Auditor signs LONG WAY DOWN over to you. Playable: the only fast heavyweight in the game — special 'Jackknife,' a sweeping trailer slam. Budget-breaking because it ignores the speed/armor tradeoff every other character pays.

6.5 The Sexton

I've dug a hole for everyone who's ever raced here. Yours has been ready a while.

Quick Reference

Bound to	The Cemetery (5.5)
Vehicle	Mausoleum on a hearse chassis ('Plot')
Boss Special	The Buried
Speed	4
Armor	10
Handling	5
Special Power	12
Stat Total	31 (exceeds the 24 budget by design)
Class	Summoner / lifesteal attrition

Backstory

The Sexton may be the only Collector who was never a contestant; he claims he was simply always the gravedigger of Hollow Hill, and that he has buried every loser of every tournament for as long as there has been a Ledger. Whether he is a damned man or a fixture of the place, he keeps the cemetery, and the cemetery keeps the dead, and the dead, when he calls, come up to race.

Vehicle Design

A mausoleum on a hearse chassis — a stone crypt grafted to a 1930s funeral coach, grave-dirt spilling from its seams, a bell on top that tolls when he summons. It drives slow and certain, like a procession. The plate reads PLOT.

Boss Special & Fight Design

Fought in the Cemetery, in the fog. Phase 1: he summons 'the buried' — spectral wrecks of past contestants' cars (you fight ghost versions of the launch roster's vehicles as adds) that fade in and out with the map's fog; he heals a little for every add that dies near him (he reclaims the dead). Phase 2 (50%): the fog turns thick and permanent — line-of-sight is gone, and he's at home in it while you aren't; homing weapons and sound become your only read. More adds. Phase 3 (25%): he stops summoning and digs — the Plot's hearse-back opens and tries to drag you into an open grave (an instant-down grab if it connects). Window: when he tolls the bell to

summon, the crypt is open and exposed. Tell: the bell toll means a summon or a grab is incoming.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Kind, patient, grandfatherly — a man comfortable with death because he's tucked in so many. Never threatening; only certain.

Fight Intro

The fog rolls in early. A bell tolls once. The headstones nearest you all bear your name and today's date. 'No rush. They all get here eventually.'

On Defeat — Playable Unlock

He tips an imaginary hat, climbs down, and lies down in the open grave himself — finally off the clock. The Auditor signs PLOT over to you. Playable: a summoner/lifesteal attrition character — special 'The Buried' raises two ghost-adds to fight for you and heals you on their death. Budget-breaking sustain.

6.6 Undertow

The river took its time with me. It's got nothing but time. So do I, now.

Quick Reference

Bound to	The Drowned Quarter (5.7)
Vehicle	Amphibious salvage-dredge rig ('Deadrise')
Boss Special	Undertow
Speed	6
Armor	9
Handling	7
Special Power	10
Stat Total	32 (exceeds the 24 budget by design)
Class	Amphibious skirmisher / drag control

Backstory

The dam-keeper of Ashen Hollow — a past contestant who wished away the night he opened the spillway too late and drowned the low quarter. He lost. The Auditor gave him the water: he lives in it now, amphibious, at home in the deep channels that kill everyone else, dragging racers down to see what he saw.

Vehicle Design

A salvage and dredge rig — a barnacled amphibious truck on pontoon-tracks, with a grapple-dredge arm and a diver's-bell cab streaming black water. It moves through deep channels at full speed where others die. The plate reads DEADRISE.

Boss Special & Fight Design

He owns the deep water: he can drive (fast) in channels that are instant-death to you, sniping from safety, and uses the dredge arm to grab vehicles on the shallows and drag them into the deep. Phase 1: hit-and-run from the channels; you must use high ground and bait him onto the flats. Phase 2 (50%): he triggers the dam — the Tidal Surge hazard fires far more often, and he rides the surge like a wave, slamming into you with it. Phase 3 (25%): the whole quarter floods a level higher; your safe ground shrinks to rooftops; he circles like a shark. Window: when he beaches himself to grab you on the flats, he's slow and exposed for ~2 seconds. Tell: the dredge arm rises before a grab; the dam klaxon before a surge.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Wet, slow, gargling; speaks of depth and pressure and how quiet it is down there.

Fight Intro

The water rises a foot the moment you enter. Something big moves under the black surface, parallel to you, patient. 'Come down where it's quiet.'

On Defeat — Playable Unlock

He sinks, finally, all the way, and the water stills. The Auditor signs DEADRISE over to you. Playable: an amphibious skirmisher — special 'Undertow,' a grapple that drags an enemy and spins up a damaging whirlpool. Budget-breaking mobility (ignores water hazards on any aquatic arena).

6.7 Lodestone

Everything's scrap eventually. I'm just early.

Quick Reference

Bound to	The Switchyard (5.8)
Vehicle	Magnet scrapyard crane on tracks ('Lodestone')
Boss Special	Magnet
Speed	3
Armor	13
Handling	2
Special Power	12
Stat Total	30 (exceeds the 24 budget by design)
Class	Hard-control juggernaut

Backstory

A scrapyard man from a past tournament who fed more than metal into the crusher — who made bodies disappear for the right price and wished away the one that finally pointed back at

him. He lost. The Auditor made him the yard: he sorts the living from the scrap now, and to him there is no difference.

Vehicle Design

A mobile scrapyards crane with a giant electromagnet and a baler-crusher maw, tracks instead of wheels, hung with crushed car-cubes. It commands the yard's Ghost Train. The plate, crushed, reads LODESTONE.

Boss Special & Fight Design

Signature gimmick: the electromagnet can lift your vehicle clean off the ground (telegraphed by a rising hum and the magnet swinging over you), hold you helpless for ~2 seconds, and slam you down or drop you onto a live track. Phase 1: magnet grabs and lobbed car-cubes; you break line-of-sight behind boxcars to deny the magnet. Phase 2 (50%): he commands the Ghost Train — it runs far more often, on tracks he chooses, and he tries to magnet you onto a hot rail. Phase 3 (25%): the magnet goes nearly constant; you fight to stay un-grabbed while he's nearly immobile but the whole yard is a trap. Window: while the magnet holds a car-cube to throw it can't grab you, and right after a slam the crane is exposed. Tell: a rising electrical hum means the magnet is charging.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Industrial, terse, indifferent; rates everything by the ton.

Fight Intro

Your wheels leave the ground for a sickening second, then drop. A hum builds across the whole yard. 'Two tons, give or take. Light. You'll bale easy.'

On Defeat — Playable Unlock

The magnet dies mid-lift and drops its last load; the crane goes still and rusts in real time. The Auditor signs LODESTONE over to you. Playable: a hard-control juggernaut — special 'Magnet,' lift-and-slam an enemy (or pull a pickup to yourself). Budget-breaking lockdown.

6.8 The Headliner — “Mr. Marrow”

Ladies and gentlemen, children of all ages — and oh, there are no children anymore, are there. Well. The show goes on.

Quick Reference

Bound to	Pinewood Drive-In & Fairground (5.9)
Vehicle	Carnival parade-float funhouse rig ('The Big Top')
Boss Special	Showtime
Speed	7
Armor	8
Handling	6

Special Power	13
Stat Total	34 (exceeds the 24 budget by design)
Class	Chaos / misdirection

Backstory

Not a clown — a children's-television host. 'Marrow the Marvelous,' beloved across three counties in the 1970s, whose live-audience show at the Pinewood lot ended the night the grandstand he'd insisted was safe collapsed under two hundred kids. He wished away the collapse in a past tournament. He lost. The Auditor gave him the eternal show: he performs now, forever, to a fairground of the dead, and the only ticket he sells is yours.

Vehicle Design

A carnival parade-float and funhouse rig — a rolling stage of cracked mirrors, fairy lights, a calliope, and animatronic clowns and animals that move wrong, with a spotlight rig on top. It fires fireworks and confetti-shrapnel. The plate reads THE BIG TOP. Marrow himself is a tall, gaunt, grease-painted man in a moth-eaten host's blazer — uncanny, not goofy.

Boss Special & Fight Design

The spectacle fight. Phase 1: fireworks barrages (telegraphed arcs of light) and animatronic adds (wind-up clowns that scuttle and pop) while he activates the map's rides against you. Phase 2 (50%): 'AUDIENCE PARTICIPATION' — the funhouse mirrors on his float spawn duplicate decoys of himself; you have to find the real Marrow among the reflections (the real one casts a shadow). Phase 3 (25%): the grand finale — every ride wakes at once, the screen blazes white, and he rains fireworks while laughing: pure bullet-hell chaos. Window: the real Marrow is exposed during his bow after each big firework volley. Tell: a drumroll on the calliope before the finale barrage.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Manic, warm, a showman's patter that curdles; he addresses you as a beloved studio audience. The saddest of the Collectors when the patter slips.

Fight Intro

The drive-in screen flares to life showing YOU, from above, entering the lot. A spotlight hits you. Applause from an empty grandstand. 'Our special guest has arrived! Give them a hand — they'll need it.'

On Defeat — Playable Unlock

The lights die, the calliope winds down, and for one second he is just a tired old man in greasepaint who whispers '...is the show over?' before he is gone. The Auditor signs THE BIG TOP over to you. Playable: a chaos/zone character — special 'Showtime,' a fireworks barrage plus a decoy of yourself. Budget-breaking output and misdirection.

6.9 The Alienist

You're agitated. That's alright. We have a treatment for everything here. Hold still.

Quick Reference

Bound to	Saint Dymphna's (5.10)
Vehicle	Mobile ECT treatment rig ('Convulsion')
Boss Special	Treatment
Speed	4
Armor	10
Handling	5
Special Power	13
Stat Total	32 (exceeds the 24 budget by design)
Class	Control / disruption

Backstory

Dr. Lucian Frost, director of Saint Dymphna's until it closed — a man who 'treated' with ice baths, ECT without anesthetic, and a lobotomy pick, and called it care. He wished away the ledger of what he'd done to the patients no one came for. He lost. The Auditor kept him on staff: he runs the empty hospital forever, and every racer who enters is a new admission.

Vehicle Design

A mobile treatment rig — a converted hospital gurney-truck and ECT cart, trailing cables that arc with current, restraint straps flapping, a single caged headlight like a reflector lamp. The plate reads CONVULSION.

Boss Special & Fight Design

He weaponizes the map's arc-and-collapse hazard and adds mind-games. Phase 1: electrical arcs (he triggers the floor-current hazard at will to herd you) and a 'sedation' projectile that slows you and blurs your HUD. Phase 2 (50%): 'TREATMENT' — he inverts and scrambles your controls in short bursts (like Pup's special, but repeatedly, as a boss), and the corridors' lights cut to black between his strobing arcs, so you fight in stutter-frames. Phase 3 (25%): he 'discharges' — full-power arcs chain continuously across every wet surface; you must stay on the few dry islands while he hunts you. Window: after each big discharge his rig must recharge (cables slacken, headlight dims) for ~2.5 seconds. Tell: the lights buzz up to full brightness right before an arc.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Gentle, clinical, relentlessly reassuring — the bedside manner of a man who has never once doubted he was helping. The Surgeon's mirror, and the contrast is the point.

Fight Intro

The ward doors lock behind you with a buzzer. The PA pages 'Dr. Frost to admissions.' Every light in the corridor surges. 'There, there. You'll feel a little pressure.'

On Defeat — Playable Unlock

His rig sparks out; the cables fall still; the PA finally stops paging him, and the silence is the kindest thing the building has heard in thirty years. The Auditor signs CONVULSION over to you. Playable: a control and debuff specialist — special 'Treatment,' a cone that scrambles enemy controls and HUD. Budget-breaking disruption.

6.10 The Auditor — “The Closing Entry”

You've done so well. You've balanced every account but the last one. Shall we?

Quick Reference

Bound to	The Auditor's Office (5.6) — final boss
Vehicle	A shifting black town-car that is never twice the same
Boss Special	Audit (copies any unlocked character's special)
Speed	■
Armor	■
Handling	■
Special Power	■
Stat Total	Redacted — the game lies to you about his stats
Class	Final boss / ultimate unlock

Backstory

Everything the bible has built toward. The Auditor is not a person but a process — the universe's enforcement when too many debts accumulate (Section 2.2). In the Office, after a contestant has run the gauntlet, he stops being polite. This is the only fight where the arena, the rules, and your own kit are not reliably yours.

Vehicle Design

He doesn't drive a vehicle so much as wear one — a shifting black town-car that is sometimes a hearse, sometimes the armored car Vault drives, sometimes a thing with no wheels at all, its license plate always reading a different contestant's name. He fights from inside the non-Euclidean Office, a space that obeys him.

Boss Special & Fight Design

The capstone, escalating the Section 5.6 reality-glitch hazard into a weapon. Phase 1 — 'Review': he copies, using the signature special of any character the player has unlocked,

cycling through them; the player must recognize and counter their own roster turned against them. Phase 2 — 'Redaction': he strips the player's own special (an extended, repeated version of Vault's Redaction) and reshuffles the arena mid-attack, doorways re-routing as you flee. Phase 3 — 'The Closing Entry': the Office collapses into a single shrinking room; he drops all tricks and simply tries to balance the account directly — a relentless, high-damage pursuit while papers (each one a struck entry, a dead contestant's page) storm the room as hazards. Window: each time he uses a copied special, he is locked to that character's weakness for its duration — the roster knowledge you built is the only way through. Tell: the plate on his car flashes the name of whoever's special he is about to use.

Voice & Dialogue Style

Unfailingly polite, soft, never raised — exactly as established — until the very end, when, for a single line, he sounds tired in a way that suggests he has wanted to lose for a very long time.

Fight Intro

No arena loads. The screen is just his desk, and the book. He closes a file — yours — and stands. 'I've enjoyed your company. That is not something I say. Let's see what you've learned.' The Office assembles around you both.

On Defeat — Playable Unlock

Defeating the Auditor is the climax of any contestant's campaign. The book falls open; the pages tear free; his form flickers. But where Vault's ending closes the Ledger for good (Section 3.16), defeating the Auditor here, as an ordinary contestant, ends with him doing something he has never done — signing his own page over: 'A debt is a debt. I balanced yours. Now you hold mine.' Playable unlock (the longest road in the game — available only after every other Collector has been claimed and the Auditor defeated): THE AUDITOR himself becomes selectable — the charcoal-suit figure in the shifting black car — whose special, 'Audit,' lets the player borrow (copy) the special of any other character on the roster at will, on a shared cooldown. He is the single most overpowered pick in the game, the reward for the longest road, and, like all Collectors, he wears his own seal: fiction's wink that the house has, just this once, let you play as the house. This does not erase Vault or his true ending; Vault remains the 'all-character-endings' narrative unlock and the only path that closes the Ledger rather than inheriting it.

7. PRODUCTION ROADMAP

This roadmap targets a solo or very small team. Adjust the timelines if you bring on collaborators. Note that v0.2 roughly doubled the content scope of v0.1 (fifteen characters, ten arenas, ten bespoke boss fights), and v0.3 adds a fourteen-weapon pickup pool and destructible, transformable arenas; the estimates below account for both.

7.1 Phase 0 — Foundation (1-2 months)

- Install Unreal Engine, Visual Studio 2022, and Git LFS. Verify build pipeline.
- Complete Unreal's official 'Your First Hour in Unreal Engine' and one full intermediate tutorial (e.g., the Stack-O-Bot template).
- Set up project repository, naming conventions, folder structure.
- Exit criterion: you can create a level, place actors, write a C++ class that compiles, and use Blueprints to wire behavior.

7.2 Phase 1 — Vehicle Prototype (2-3 months)

- Build BaseCombatVehicle C++ class with components (health, weapons, AI driver, special).
- Implement vehicle physics and driving feel. Iterate on a flat 'gym' level until the car feels right.
- Add a simple test arena with ramps, walls, jumps.
- Exit criterion: driving the test vehicle in the gym is genuinely fun with no objectives.

7.3 Phase 2 — Combat Core (2-3 months)

- Add primary fire (machine gun), one missile, health/damage, pickups.
- Build one AI opponent capable of driving and shooting (Behavior Tree + AI Controller).
- Hit-stop, screen shake, basic particle and sound feedback.
- Exit criterion: a 2-minute fight against the AI is fun.

7.4 Phase 3 — Vertical Slice (3-4 months)

- Build one full arena (recommend The Mill — best showcase).
- Build one full character (recommend The Surgeon — clear theme, solid mechanics).
- Build one full boss for that arena (recommend The Foundryman) to prove the boss-fight loop and the unlock-on-defeat flow early.
- Prototype one signature destructible feature (recommend The Mill's catwalk collapse) to prove dynamic geometry and runtime navmesh rebuilds before committing to the rest.
- Add 3-4 AI opponents using placeholder vehicles for variety.
- Implement menus, basic UI, victory/defeat states.
- 30-second intro cutscene and 60-90 second ending cinematic for The Surgeon (can be motion-comic style if budget is tight).
- Exit criterion: a stranger can play this slice — a fight, a boss, an unlock, a map that changes — and have fun. This is your demo, your Steam Next Fest entry, your pitch material.

7.5 Phase 4 — Production (18-30 months)

- Expand to the full 15-character launch roster.
- Build the remaining arenas (to ten total).
- Implement the ten Collector bosses and the unlock-on-defeat system.
- Implement the full fourteen-weapon pickup pool.
- Build the two-to-three destructible/interactive set-pieces per arena (Section 5), with dynamic navigation so the AI handles a changing map.
- Story mode wiring, all cutscenes, all dialogue, both endgame unlock paths (Vault and the Auditor).
- Decision point: cut multiplayer from v1. Add post-launch as free update.
- Exit criterion: feature-complete game playable start to finish.

7.6 Phase 5 — Polish & Steam Release (4-6 months)

- Steamworks SDK integration, achievements, cloud saves.
- ESRB/PEGI rating submission.
- Demo for Steam Next Fest (3 months pre-launch).
- Boss balance pass — tells, windows, and difficulty scaling tuned across all ten fights.
- Bug fixing, optimization, polish pass.
- Launch.

7.7 Realistic Total Estimate

With the expanded v0.2/v0.3 scope: solo developer, 4-6 years; with one collaborator, 3-4 years; small team of 3-4, 2-3 years. The single biggest risk is scope creep — and v0.2 and v0.3 are themselves large, deliberate increases in scope. Every feature beyond this list must be justified by reference to the design pillars. See the scope notes in Sections 8.4 and 8.5.

8. SCOPE GUARDRAILS

This section exists to be re-read whenever you feel like adding something.

8.1 What This Game Is

- A single-player vehicular combat game with arena-style fights.
- Fifteen playable characters with full story arcs.
- Ten arenas in one city, each gated by a boss fight and reshaped by two to three destructible, interactive set-pieces.
- Ten unlockable Collector bosses (plus Vault, plus the Auditor) earned through play.
- Fourteen shared pickup weapons, found and fought over on the map.
- Dark, atmospheric, tightly-themed horror.

8.2 What This Game Is NOT (At Launch)

- Not multiplayer (post-launch update target).
- Not an open world.
- Not a vehicle customization sandbox (set rosters only).
- Not a roguelike (defined campaigns per character).
- Not VR.
- Not multi-platform at launch (PC first; consoles after success).

8.3 The Cut Rule

If a proposed feature does not serve at least one design pillar, cut it. If it serves a pillar but doubles the development time of its phase, cut it. If you cannot describe it in one sentence, cut it.

Every feature you add is a feature you must finish, test, balance, debug, document, and ship. Ambition is not the same as scope. Choose ambition. Ruthlessly limit scope.

8.4 Scope Note for v0.2

v0.2 nearly doubles the content of v0.1: almost twice the characters, nearly twice the arenas, and ten bespoke boss fights that did not exist before. This is a real and deliberate increase in ambition, and it is in tension with the Cut Rule above — honestly so. That tension is healthy as long as it is managed rather than ignored. Recommended approach:

- Treat the original eight characters, one arena, and one boss as the vertical slice and v1 spine. Prove the full loop — drive, fight, boss, unlock, ending — before committing to the rest.
- Treat the seven new characters and the ten Collector bosses as tiers that can ship in waves if needed: a launch roster you can defend, then post-launch character/boss drops, rather than a single all-or-nothing release.

- Hold the line elsewhere. The bigger the roster and boss count grow, the more ruthless Sections 8.2 and 8.3 must be about everything else. No multiplayer at launch, no open world, no customization — those cuts are what buy the expanded roster.
- Every new character and boss must still pass the one-sentence test and serve a pillar. They do today; keep it that way as the list grows.

8.5 Scope Note for v0.3

v0.3 adds six pickups and two to three destructible or interactive set-pieces per arena. The pickups are cheap — shared systems, reusable across the whole roster — and safe to keep. The destructible features are not: dynamic geometry, navigation meshes that rebuild mid-match, and AI that understands a map which changes shape are among the most expensive things a small team can attempt. Recommendation: ship one signature transformation per arena first (the headline set-piece), prove it in the vertical slice, and treat the second and third features per map as post-launch polish. Do not let 'the map changes' quietly become 'the map is unshippable.'

DOCUMENT CHANGELOG

v0.1 — Initial draft. Eight characters (seven detailed), six arenas, full weapon roster, production roadmap.

v0.2 — Expanded the launch roster to fifteen playable characters, adding The Lien, Hemlock, The Shepherd, Specter, Refuse, The Bride, The Hunter, and The Photographer (and resolving v0.1's eight-listed / seven-detailed discrepancy; Vault renumbered to 3.16). Hemlock added per design request as an eco-saboteur. Expanded to ten arenas, adding The Drowned Quarter, The Switchyard, Pinewood Drive-In & Fairground, and Saint Dymphna's. Introduced the Collections: ten overpowered Collector bosses, one per arena, each unlockable as a playable character on defeat (Section 6). Added boss-combat design philosophy (Section 4.6). Restructured the campaign around the ten arenas and their boss gates (Section 2.5). Added the Auditor as the final boss and ultimate unlock (Section 6.10), preserved alongside Vault's true ending. Revised the production roadmap and scope guardrails to reflect the larger scope (Sections 7 and 8.4).

v0.3 — Expanded the pickup pool from eight to fourteen, adding the Spike Strip, Concussion Charge, Arc Lance, Process Server, Effigy, and Final Notice (Section 4.3) — each chosen to fill a tactical niche the original pool left open. Added two to three destructible and interactive features to every arena (Section 5): Eiffel Tower-style set-pieces, several of which permanently open new drivable areas, reroute the battlefield, or turn the map's own hazards into weapons. Updated the cover, scope summary, and roadmap to match (Sections 8.1, 8.5, 7).

Future revisions should be tracked here. Living document — expect every section to evolve through development.